

Slang & Informal English

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What exactly is slang?

It's difficult to define slang perfectly, but here are a few of its characteristics:

- Slang is informal, less serious, often non-standard English.
- Slang often comes from a group of people who are familiar with the terms and use them with each other.
- Slang is often used for uncomfortable topics (sex and bodily functions) or criticisms/insults, to say these things in a more playful or less direct way.

It is important to understand slang, because you may hear it often in informal conversations, movies and TV shows.

However, it is also important to understand that slang should NEVER be used in professional situations, academic situations, and when talking with someone in a more formal social situation (someone important or someone who you respect).

Use slang when joking around with your friends, but do NOT use it when talking with a colleague, teacher, religious or political leader, or your grandmother! Some of the words can be very offensive.

Slang changes very quickly - as new words and expressions are invented, others go out of fashion, and others actually become an official part of the language.

This book presents a selection of the most current and common American English slang words, organized by topic with lots of examples to show you exactly how they are used.

Each word is also classified according to how offensive it is:

- **Red** = Extremely offensive
- **Yellow** = Somewhat offensive – use with caution
- **Green** = Non-offensive (or only a little bit) – but again, remember that even the green words are “informal” English and should not be used in more formal contexts.

Difference between Slang and Idioms

Idioms are expressions that cannot be translated literally, word for word – for example, the expression "that's a piece of cake" meaning something is easy.

Idioms are used more frequently than slang, especially in informal English. You CAN use idioms in casual conversations with co-workers and people who you respect.

Idioms should only be avoided in very formal writing and presentation - such as an academic paper or a business report.

The distinction between slang and idioms is not perfect, and this book includes idioms as well when related to the topic at hand.

Slang Words for People

This is one of the biggest categories, as there are many slang words for people based on their experience, character, and behavior.

GENERAL WORDS

Dude and **guy** are general words for a man, and **gal** and **chick** are general words for a woman. We often use these words when we don't know who the person is (though not necessarily, as in the last example).

- "I asked a **guy** on the street if I could borrow his phone to make a call."
- "That **dude** in the red shirt is totally drunk."
- "Who's the tall blonde **chick** over there talking to Brian?"
- "My sister's more of a city **gal**, as for me I prefer the countryside."

Guy and **gal** are probably a little more common; **dude** and **chick** tend to be used more by men (though not always).

For family, we have:

- **bro** and **sis** for brother and sister, although they can also be used for very close friends
- **pops** or **old man** for father
- **gramps** and **gran/granny** for grandfather and grandmother

- **My folks** for “my relatives” or “my parents”
- **The whole tribe/clan** for your entire family, especially extended family

Examples:

- “Happy birthday to my big **sis!**”
(*big sis = older sister; little sis = younger sister*)
- “My **gramps** is 84 but he still loves to play tennis.”
- “Sorry, I can’t hang out this weekend – **my folks** are in town.”
(*= my parents are here in my city visiting me*)
- “Do you see your family much?”
“Not really. Every August **the whole clan** gets together for an end-of-summer barbecue, but that’s about it.”

Slang words for “friend” include **buddy, pal,** and **chum,** and the *group* of your typical friends can be called **the crew.** We also have the word **peeps** (short for “people”) which can mean people in general, or your group of friends (“my peeps”).

- “Peter is one of my old **pals** from college.”
- “I went to the amusement park with **the crew.**”
- “I’m gonna invite all **my peeps** to my going-away party.”

If two people are **buddy-buddy,** it means they are good friends or have a close relationship. This word can also be used for *trying* or *appearing* to have a close relationship, as in the second and third examples:

- “My brother’s wife is an actress, she’s not so famous herself but apparently she’s **buddy-buddy** with some of the top directors in Hollywood.”
- “I don’t understand how someone can be all **buddy-buddy** with their ex-boyfriends. I never want to see any of my exes again!”
- “How can you expect to be all **buddy-buddy** with me after what you did?!”

The slang words **homeboy, homegirl,** and **homie,** are also used for friends – these are more African-American or hip-hop style. They are usually used with “my.”

- My **homeboy** won first place in the karate competition!
- I went to the mall with my **homegirl.**
- I had an awesome weekend with my **homies** from the soccer team.

The words **bud/buddy** and **dude** can also be used for addressing a person (a man) who you don’t know in a slightly hostile way, like when a fight is about to start:

- What's your problem, **dude**?
- Hey **bud**, stop staring at my girlfriend!
- Look, **buddy**, I'll give you till the count of five to get out of my way.

Some older, more "refined" slang words for "man" include **chap, fellow**, and **gent** (short for gentleman – a good, courteous man).

- My sister's boyfriend is a friendly **chap**. Everyone likes him.
- He's a handsome **fellow** with blue eyes and dark brown hair.
- Fred spent six hours helping me move into my new apartment. What a **gent**!

A funny, kind of ironic way to refer to yourself is **yours truly** – often when calling attention to something good involving yourself:

- This whole party was organized by **yours truly**.
- Check out the photo of **yours truly** in today's newspaper!

APPEARANCE & AGE

A common slang word for someone who is attractive is to say they are **hot** (adj.) or call them **a hottie** (n.):

- "That lifeguard is **hot**!"
- "Let's go talk to those **hotties** playing volleyball."

Cute (adj.) and **a cutie** (n.) are also used for attractive people (both children and adults), but these have more of a playful/sweet connotation, whereas **hot/hottie** is sexier and only used for teenagers/adults.

- "Here's a photo of my 5-year old son. Isn't he **a cutie**?"
- "Chris isn't the hottest guy in my class, but he is kinda **cute**."

Other slang words for attractive people include:

- **a ten / a perfect ten**
This probably comes from rating people's appearance on a scale of 1 to 10.
- **a looker / a stunner**
"Wow, that flight attendant is a looker. I wonder if she's single?"

- **hot stuff**
"He's not my favorite actor, but I watch all his movies 'cause I think he's hot stuff!"
- **foxy** (usually used for women, with "lady")
"She is one foxy lady for sure. She could be a model."
- **a stud / a hunk** (only for men)
"One of my coworkers is a major hunk, I get nervous every time I talk to him."
- **a babe** (usually for women, although occasionally for men as well)
"That babe over there in the red bikini is checking you out, dude!"
(checking you out = looking at you as if she is attracted to you)

If someone is very athletic, with very well-defined muscles, we can say they are **buff** or **ripped**. Some derogatory words for a very skinny person are a **string bean** or a **twig**, and there are many derogatory slang words for a fat person, including **fat ass** and **lard-ass**. A word making fun of someone who is short and rather weak is a **shrimp**.

- "He started lifting weights six months ago, and now he's totally **ripped**."
- "I was such a **twig** when I was a teenager; I couldn't gain weight no matter what."
- "You're going to run a marathon? Yeah right. You're such a **fat ass** you can't even climb the stairs without getting out of breath." (*sarcastic, offensive*)
- "That **shrimp** is trying out for the basketball team? He doesn't have a chance."

Children in English are also called **kids**, and some slang terms for them are **kiddos**, **tykes / little tykes**, **munchkins**, and (less commonly) **rug rats**. These are usually used affectionately.

- "I'm taking my **kiddos** to the park this afternoon."
- "The **little tyke** cries every time I take him to the dentist."
- "We went on vacation with my best friend, her husband, and their three little **munchkins**."

The word **brat** means a child who has bad manners and expects to get his/her own way all the time, behaving badly in order to manipulate adults into giving them what they want. You can also call an adult a **brat** if he/she is acting like a badly-behaved child.

Calling an adult a “baby” can be used as a term of endearment in romantic relationships, or by men looking at an attractive woman who they don’t know. But it can also be used in a negative sense, to say that someone is being immature, usually saying that they are **“such a baby”**:

- I can’t believe you’re angry that I ate the last piece of cake. You’re **such a baby**.

Some informal ways to refer to “young people” in general (can be kids, but also can be teenagers or young adults) is **young’uns**, which is short for “young ones,” or **youngsters**. These are usually used by older people when reflecting on the fact that they can’t do as much as young people can – or that they have more experience than young people do:

- “Snowboarding is definitely a sport for **youngsters**... my 60-year-old knees couldn’t take it!”
- “Our company just hired a bunch of **young’uns** who think they know everything. I’m in charge of their training.”

A young **whippersnapper** is a young person who is not important, but who acts smart and pretentious (like the new employees mentioned in the second example).

Adults around 50-60 years old who have adult children that have recently left home to start their own lives can be called **empty nesters**. This refers to a nest being a place where birds live, and when the baby birds have grown up and flown away from the nest, leaving only the parents, it feels empty.

Finally, we have several derogatory slang words for old people:

- **old geezer** (usually used for a man, especially an eccentric one)
- **old hag** (for a woman, especially an ugly and disagreeable one)
- **old fart / old fogey** (can be both men and women, especially those who have old-fashioned ideas and refuse to modernize)

Remember that these are insulting!!!

Finally, when someone looks exactly like someone else, he/she is a **dead ringer** for the other person: “People say my cousin is a **dead ringer** for Brad Pitt.”

INTELLIGENCE, BELIEFS, WORK ETHIC

Someone who is smart can be described as:

- **brainy (adj.)**
"I like to date brainy chicks who can challenge me intellectually."
- **a whiz (n.)** – especially with a specific topic (a math whiz, a computer whiz)
"My daughter is a science whiz – she's only 12 but she's reading college chemistry textbooks."
- **a smart cookie (n.)**
"Jeff is a smart cookie – he used Facebook to help grow his company to a million dollars in sales without spending a cent on advertising."

Some people make a distinction between **book smarts** (intelligence in a school/academic setting) and **street smarts** (intelligence from real-life situations, especially in an urban and rather dangerous environment).

If a person is knowledgeable about a specific area, they can be called **a buff** or **a maven** – for example, a history buff or a comic book maven.

- "My teacher is a real **grammar buff** – she knows every single rule and all its details."
- "We're looking for a **fashion maven** to help design the costumes for the play."

Someone who is arrogant about their knowledge or intelligence and always tries to show it off (especially in an annoying or sarcastic way), can be described in an insulting way as **a know-it-all, a smarty pants, a smartass, or a wise guy.**

- "I hate working with her because she's such a **know-it-all**; she's not willing to listen to anyone else's opinion."
- "Don't be a **smartass**, okay? You don't know all the facts about the situation, so you have no right to comment on it."

There are many slang words for a stupid person, such as **dope, dolt, doofus**, and **dumbass**. A stupid person that is silly and superficial is an **airhead** – like their head is full of air and has no solid substance. Another word for "airhead" is **ditz** (this is more frequently used for women).

- "He keeps insisting that he's right, despite all the evidence to the contrary. What a **dolt**!"
- "That **dumbass** crashed his new car the same day he bought it."
- "She's a total **airhead**; she talks a lot but says nothing remotely interesting."

There's a special word for someone who is easily deceived – they are a **sucker**. This word can also be used to say someone is a **sucker for [something]** – meaning they have a special weakness for that thing.

- “I can't believe John bought a 'gold' watch on the street for \$50. Of course it wasn't real gold; he's just a **sucker**.”
- “I'm on a diet, but I'm such a **sucker for chocolate chip cookies** that I couldn't resist eating a couple.”

What about a crazy person? Slang words for “crazy” include:

- **a nut** (n.) / **nuts** (adj.)
- **loopy** (adj.)
- **wacko** (n., adj.)
- **a basket case** (n.)
- **psycho** (n., adj.) – short for “psychotic.” This word is often used for a person who is crazy AND dangerous to others; someone who bombs a school full of kids is a **psycho**.

If you have relatives with some crazy ideas, you could say:

- “My uncle believes his mind is controlled by aliens. He's a complete **wacko**. And my aunt is **nuts**, too. She has all these **loopy** ideas about communicating with ghosts by magic.”

Someone who rigidly enforces rules and regulations, and does not accept excuses, is a **hard-ass**. A student might complain about a teacher:

- “Mrs. Johnson's a real **hard-ass**. I turned in my paper just 20 minutes after the deadline, and she took ten points off my grade for lateness.”

Similar to that is a person who is excessively concerned with the correctness of details – this person is **anal retentive** (or sometimes **anal** for short). If your friend Bill believes EXTREMELY strongly in eating organic food, and refuses to eat anything that has even a tiny bit of a non-organic ingredient, you could say:

- “Bill is really **anal** about his all-natural diet. Don't even think about offering him anything that's not organic.”

People like this often **have some hang-ups**. A “hang-up” is when you are obsessed or have an excessive focus on something, or something bothers you excessively (usually some small thing):

- “My wife **has a hang-up** about the way her books are organized. She yells at me if I accidentally put a book back on the shelf in the wrong place!”
- “Bob’s **got a real hang-up** about his height. He’s so insecure that he imagines no woman will ever want to date a short guy like him.”

Someone who is new or not yet very experienced in an area is a **rookie** or a **newbie**, and someone who doesn’t like to work is a **bum** (often a **lazy bum**). A person who is unreliable can be called **flaky** or **a flake** – usually when someone makes a commitment or agreement, but then doesn’t do it. The opposite – someone who works hard and takes initiative – can be called a **go-getter**.

- “Can you teach me how to use this computer program? I’m a complete **rookie**.”
- “My ex-husband is a **lazy bum** who has never managed to stay in a job for more than six months at a time.”
- “Barbara is really **flaky**. Pretty much every time we make plans together, she either cancels at the last minute or just doesn’t show up.”

We also have some derogatory words for people with strong beliefs:

- **a bible thumper** = strong Christian, especially someone who tries to convert others or insist that the laws follow Christian values
- **a tree hugger** = an environmentalist, especially one who goes to ridiculous extremes to protect the environment
- **a bleeding heart** = a person considered excessively sympathetic towards those who are apparently underprivileged

PRIDE & BRAVERY

Two slang words for someone who is arrogant and annoying are **stuck up** and **snotty**. If you say someone **“thinks he is God’s gift to [women / the planet / the company]”** it means that person has a very high opinion of himself, as if God sent him personally.

- “I can’t stand **snotty** people who think they’re all superior just because they went to a top university.”
- “Tom’s constantly saying he’s ‘destined for greatness.’ He really **thinks he’s God’s gift to humanity**.”

When someone wants to be the center of attention, they are an **attention whore**. Similar to that is a **diva**, a vain person who is full of drama and expects all the best treatment (this word can also be used in a good sense, for a famous female singer).

- “Ellen posts so many pictures of her ‘fabulous life’ on her blog. She says she wants to inspire others, but I think she’s just an **attention whore**.”
- “She’s staying in a cheap hotel and is whining about the fact that it doesn’t have a spa. What a **diva**!”

A very specific type of diva is a **bridezilla** – a woman who is getting married and who becomes a “monster” because she is so demanding and picky about all the details of the wedding, even being cruel to others in order to get her own way on her “perfect” day.

- “My cousin’s kind of hard to get along with, and before her wedding she turned into a total **bridezilla**. She even screamed at the musicians when they made a small mistake during the wedding rehearsal.”

When someone who *used to be* popular, famous, or successful is no longer famous, this person is a **has-been**. The opposite is a **wannabe** – someone who wishes/wants to be successful or famous.

- “The athlete is trying to make a comeback as a coach because he can’t accept the fact that he’s just an old **has-been** and everyone’s already forgotten about him.”
- “With the internet, every **wannabe** writer can now publish their own blog.”

When someone has courage, we often say they have **guts** or they are **gutsy**.

- “Laura left her home and moved halfway around the world to take a job in a country where she didn’t speak the language – she’s really got **guts**!”

There are many slang words for someone who is not brave, who has no courage:

- **a chicken** (n.)
- **a scaredy-cat** (n.) – often used by/with children
- **a sissy** (n.)
- **a wimp** (n.)
- **a wuss** (n.) – often used by men

- **a pussy** (n.) – often used by men about other men. It is very offensive as it compares the man to a “weak” woman. “Pussy” is also slang for the female genitalia.

Here are some examples:

- “Come on, let’s try out a belly-dancing class. Don’t be such a **chicken**, it’ll be fun!”
- “If you want to change your life, you have to take action. You can’t be a **wimp**.”
- “What do you mean you don’t drink?! Stop being a **pussy** and have a beer.”

A person who does not stand up for themselves, who always lets other people control them, is a **doormat** or a **pushover**. Like a literal doormat, which people walk on top of.

- “I wanted to say no to the volunteering commitment, but my husband is a **doormat** and he told his friend we’d volunteer every weekend for the entire summer.”
- “Don’t be a **pushover**. If your boss wants you to do something unethical, you should refuse – even if it means losing your job.”

Other ways to describe someone who does not have strong willpower, or who is weak and timid, is to say they are **spineless** or **have no backbone**.

A specific way to describe a man who always gives in to his wife/girlfriend is **whipped** or **pussy whipped**, and if a woman has the primary control in the relationship, we say she **wears the pants in the relationship/family**.

- “That politician is so **spineless**; he makes big promises, but **doesn’t have the backbone** to push for major reforms.”
- “Alex is **whipped** – he does everything his wife tells him to. She’s the one who **wears the pants** in that relationship.”

Finally, someone who cries easily is a **crybaby**.

- “What a **crybaby**! I made a few suggestions for ways she could improve her project, and she burst into tears, saying nobody appreciated her work.”

SOCIAL GROUP/STATUS

People who live in cities sometimes consider those who live in the countryside to be inferior, less modern, less educated, and less cultured. Some slang words for a person from a rural area are **hick**, **hillbilly**, and **redneck** (this last one can be offensive).

- “My cousin is such a **hillbilly**. When she came to visit me in the city, she had no clue how to take the subway because she’d never done it before!”
- “He went from being a small-town **hick** to an internationally-known singer in just five years.”

A person who is a little bit strange and who doesn’t fit in with the popular group, or with the “normal” people, can be called an **oddball** (this word is less strong), **freak**, or **weirdo** (these words are stronger). Calling someone a **loser** is an insulting way to say that they are NOT cool and NOT talented.

- “I’ve always been kind of an **oddball**. I enjoy obscure topics and I don’t follow pop culture at all.”
- “Aaron is obsessed with sci-fi, and he even dresses up like some of his favorite characters. What a **weirdo**.”
- “I felt like a real **loser** when I threw a big holiday party and nobody came.”

A person who is very shy, especially in social situations, can be called a **wallflower**, and someone who prefers to spend time alone is a **loner** or a **lone wolf**. In high school and college, athletes are often called **jocks** and people who study a lot (and are not very “cool”) are **geeks** or **nerds**.

- “Pamela’s a bit of a **wallflower**, she keeps to herself and waits for people to go up and talk to her.”
- “Ryan is a **loner**, I don’t think he has any close friends.”
- “The **jocks** were always the most popular guys in school; none of the girls were ever interested in a computer **geek** like me.”

When talking about celebrities or other famous people, the term **A-lister** means someone who is among the MOST famous/popular in that category. In business or other organizations (such as gangs), the person in the top position of power can be called the **head honcho** or the **big kahuna**.

- “I spotted a couple of **A-listers** at that restaurant in Los Angeles.”

- “Nate has a ton of experience; he was the **head honcho** at a multinational company for more than 10 years.”

Other slang terms for “important, powerful people” include the **big dogs, big boys**, and **a big shot**. “Big shot” is sometimes used ironically, for someone who *thinks* they are important, or who shows off their importance arrogantly. People in positions of power have a lot of **clout** (influence).

- “She’s the top advisor to many of the **big dogs** in the marketing industry.”
- “When celebrities commit crimes, they can often get a **big-shot** lawyer to defend them.”
- “He may not be the leading candidate for president, but he has a lot of **clout** in the Latino community.”

There are many slang words that describe people based on their race, but I will not teach them here because they are offensive. However, I want to make one comment on the word **nigger**. This is a disparaging term for a black person, but some black people nowadays do use it (with a neutral/positive connotation) among each other.

There is a debate in the African-American community about this; some people believe it is OK to reclaim a word previously used as an insult, while others believe that nobody should ever use this word again. So, although you may hear it in some movies and music, it’s best never to use it!

CHARACTER / PERSONALITY

Someone who treats others badly can be described as:

- **a jerk**
- **an asshole** (stronger than “jerk”)
- **a bastard** (men only)
- **a bitch** (women only)
- **a dick / a prick** (men only)
- **a douchebag** (men only)
- **a slimeball / a scumbag** (usually men, particularly men who do something especially disgusting)

Examples:

- “Some **jerk** hit my car in the parking lot and left without leaving a note!”
- “My ex-husband was an **asshole**. He used to make fun of people with mental disabilities.”
- “After our argument, she went and told all my friends how I was a terrible person. What a **bitch!**”
- “I know you’re mad that I broke your cell phone, but you don’t have to be a **dick** about it. I already promised to pay for the repairs, so lay off.”
(*lay off* = stop verbally attacking me)
- “That **slimeball** just invited my 16-year-old sister to go home with him.”

Someone who has abnormal or disgusting sexual tendencies/actions can be described as a **perv** (short for “pervert”) or a **sicko**, and someone who is unpleasant in a threatening or possibly dangerous way is a **creep**.

- “The governor is accused of molesting several dozen children. I hope that **perv** gets life in prison.”
- “After I turned Alex down for a date, he started calling me every night. I had to change my number just to get away from that **creep**.”

On the internet, there are people who like to make rude or offensive comments in discussions just to make everyone angry. These people are called **trolls**.

Have you ever had a friend who eats your food and doesn’t help pay for it, borrows your clothes instead of buying their own, and constantly asks you for money? This person is a **mooch** or a **freeloader**, someone who constantly tries to get things for free from their friends and family. **Mooch** and **freeload** can also be used as verbs.

- “Ryan’s just a **freeloader**. He doesn’t have a job, he isn’t looking for one, and he’s been staying at his cousin’s place for the past year without helping pay rent.”
- “She’s always **mooching** off her friends – she gets them to pay for her drinks every time they go out.”

Finally, famous bands and singers often have **groupies** – extremely enthusiastic and devoted fans (often young women). An especially dedicated fan can also be called a **fanboy** or a **fangirl**. These terms make a little bit of fun of the person’s extreme dedication and love for their celebrity idol.

- “All the Justin Bieber **groupies** screamed when he stepped out of the limo.”

Someone who is very lively and entertaining is the **life of the party**. On the other hand, a **wet blanket** is a dull, depressing person who ruins others' enjoyment. Similar to that is a **stick in the mud**, someone who doesn't like to have fun – and a **fuddy-duddy** is an old-fashioned, conservative person who doesn't like progress, change, or modern things.

- “Jen is super outgoing; she’s always **the life of the party**.”
- “Look... I don’t wanna be a **wet blanket**, but I just don’t think your plan is going to work.”
- “Everyone else had a blast (= *a great time, a lot of fun*) dancing at the wedding except for Jason, who’s a total **stick in the mud**.”
- “We want to have a Christian rock concert in the church, but the pastor is an old **fuddy-duddy** who disapproves of that type of music.”

ACTIONS

Someone with bad motor coordination in general is a **klutz** (or the adjective **klutzy**), and someone who tends to drop things is a **butterfingers** (or “has butterfingers”).

- “While getting up from the couch, I lost my balance, fell flat on my face and broke my nose. I’m such a **klutz**.”
- “That’s the second dish that has slipped out of my hands this morning. I have **butterfingers** today.”

If someone sits on the couch all day (especially watching TV) and is not very physically active, they are a **couch potato**. Some couch potatoes are also **slobs** – a slob doesn’t take care of his/her appearance or living space, so everything is dirty, disorganized, and unattractive.

- “Come on kids, turn off the video games and go play outside! Don’t be **couch potatoes**!”
- “My college roommate was a major **slob**. He’d leave the sink full of his dirty dishes for weeks, until I’d get so grossed out I’d wash them myself.”

Someone who likes to collect miscellaneous objects and doesn’t like to throw anything away is a **pack rat** or a **hoarder** – “pack rat” is a more innocent,

affectionate way to refer to someone who has the hobby of keeping everything, and being a “hoarder” is more serious; it can even be a psychological problem.

- “Grandpa’s definitely a **pack rat**. He still has boxes full of his childhood toys from the 1940s!”
- “Linda is constantly taking stuff from the garbage to bring home. I wonder if she needs it or if she’s actually a **hoarder**.”

If a person HATES to spend money, and spends as little as possible, then they are a **tightwad**. This word has a negative connotation, like a person who doesn’t spend even when they really should.

- “Dana’s boyfriend is a rich lawyer, but he’s a real **tightwad** – when he proposed, he gave her a cheap \$10 ring with a fake diamond!”

Finally, we have **helicopter parents** – a type of parent who is constantly observing their child and constantly interfering in their life, like a helicopter always stays over one area. Helicopter parents also tend to be **worrywarts** – a worrywart is someone who worries too much, especially about things that don’t require so much worry.

- “I don’t think it’s healthy to be a **helicopter parent**, because you end up raising kids with no independence or self-reliance.”
- “My mom called me five times to check if I got home safely. She’s such a **worrywart**.”

Slang for the Human Body

The body in general is sometimes referred to as the **bod**:

- “These five simple exercises will give you a **bod** you won’t be ashamed to show off at the beach.”

Here are some slang/informal words for specific body parts:

- **Head** - **nut, noodle, dome, noggin, gourd**
“The book fell down from the top shelf and hit her right on the **noggin**.”
- **Face** – mug (usually used in the phrase **“ugly mug”**)
“Get outta here, I don’t want to have to look at your **ugly mug** anymore.”

- **Nose** - **schnozz, honker, beak**
(these words all refer to a BIG nose)
"He's got a nice smile, but a huge **schnozz**."
- **Eyes** - **peepers, baby blues**
(*"baby blues" is only for blue eyes*)
"Keep your **peepers** open, kids – you don't want to miss a minute of the parade!"
- **Teeth** - **choppers, ivories, pearly whites**
(A dentist might say playfully, "Open your mouth and let's have a look at those **choppers**!")
- **Mouth** - **trap, pie hole**
(The expressions "Shut your trap!" and "Shut your pie hole!" are very rude ways to tell someone to stop talking)
- **Chin** - A **"double chin"** is an extra layer of fat around a person's neck, so that it looks like they have two chins.
- **Heart** - **ticker**
(usually when talking about the health of the heart; for example, an old man might say: "My doctor says my **ticker's** still going strong!")
- **Breasts** - **boobs, girls, twins, cans, jugs, tits, rack, ta-tas**
(*boobs, girls, and twins are typically used by women. Boobs, cans, jugs, tits, rack, and ta-tas are typically used by men.*)
Woman: "I need a better sports bra; this one doesn't have enough support for my **boobs**."
Man: "She was so drunk at the party she took off her tank top and showed everyone her **tits**."
- **Muscular Arms** - **guns**
"Whoa, look at those **guns**! Do you lift weights?"

- **Flabby Arms** – **bat wings**
(refers to the fat that hangs down from your upper arms)
- **Hands** - **paws, mitts**
(often used in the expression “Take your paws off [my bike]!” – to tell someone to stop touching something)
- **Stomach (general)** - **tummy, abs** (“abs” refers specifically to the muscles)
“I did 200 sit-ups at the gym yesterday, and now my **abs** are sore.”
“I can’t believe she has such a tight **tummy** after having four kids!”
- **Fat Stomach** - **gut, belly, beer belly, pot belly, spare tire, love handles** (fat on the sides of the stomach and/or back), **muffin top** (when the front and sides of your stomach hang over the waist of your pants)
- **Muscular Stomach** - **six-pack, washboard abs**
- **Navel** - **belly button**
“I got my **belly button** pierced last year.”
- **Penis** - **dick, cock, manhood, wang, weenie, wee-wee**
(these last two are usually used with children)
- **Testicles** – **balls, nuts, family jewels, junk**
- **Vagina** - **pussy, cooter, cooch, vag, vajayjay, snatch, girly bits.** There’s also “clit” which is short for clitoris.
- **Pubic hair** – **pubes**
- **More Polite Words for the Genital Region** - **nether regions, private parts, genitals, private**
- **Bottom** - **rear end, behind, butt, booty, fanny, tush, tail, buns, duff, heinie, glutes** (referring to the muscles of your bottom), **ass, arse**

- **Legs** – **quads** (*short for quadriceps, the muscles of your thighs*), **thunder thighs** (*large, fat thighs*)
- **Feet** – **dogs**
- **Toes** – **tootsies**

When someone has no clothes on, the standard word is **naked** or **nude** – but some slang terms for this situation are being **in the buff** or **in your birthday suit**.

- “My neighbor likes to sunbathe **in the buff** in his backyard.”

Swimming naked is called **skinny-dipping**, running naked in a public place is called **streaking**, and showing your breasts or genitals to someone in a public place is **flashing** the person. If you pull down your pants and show your bare butt to someone, you are **mooning** the person.

- “I would never go **skinny-dipping** with my friends; I’m too shy.”
- “A **streaker** ran across the soccer field during halftime before being caught by the security guards.”
- “Police arrested a guy who was **flashing** random women in the train station.”
- “One of my son’s friends got suspended from school after **mooning** a teacher who told him to be more respectful in class.”

Slang words for body modifications include:

- **ink** = a tattoo, tattoos
“I just got some new **ink** on my shoulder.”
- **juice / roids** = steroids, chemicals that artificially enhance muscles
“Nobody has muscles that big naturally. He must be using **roids**.”

Slang for Bodily Functions

The two most common slang words for the action of vomiting (also called “throwing up”) are to **barf** or **puke**. There are many, many more, such as **lose your lunch** or **toss your cookies**.

- “I got sick on the airplane and **puked** all over the person sitting next to me.”
- “Peter **lost his lunch** after ten minutes on the boat.”

To release intestinal gas is to **fart, cut the cheese,** or **rip one.**

- “Ugh, what’s that smell? Who **farted?**”

Some people say **“Call of nature”** when they need to excuse themselves to go to the bathroom. To urinate is to **pee, take a leak,** or **take a piss,** and urine itself is often called **piss.**

- “I’ll be back in a minute, guys. **Call of nature.**”
- “They never clean that bathroom; there’s **piss** all over the toilet seat.”

To defecate is to **poop, take a dump, take a crap/shit,** or **go number two** – and feces can be called **poo, poop, crap,** or **shit** (the first two are more innocent and are often used with children; the last two are a little more offensive). When you have diarrhea, you can say you **have the runs.**

- “I’m constipated, I haven’t **pooped** in three days.”
- “Today started out terribly – as soon as I left the house I stepped in a big pile of dog **shit.**”
- “Whenever I eat oily food, I always **have the runs** later.”

When a woman is menstruating, we say she is having her **period.** There are also many euphemisms (indirect ways) to say it, such as, “it’s *that* time of the month.” Some women get emotional and easily upset around the time of their period, so when a woman is cranky, some people say it’s **PMS** (short for premenstrual syndrome) or **“She’s PMS-ing.”** The doctor who specializes in the female reproductive system is a gynecologist, but many women call this doctor a **gyno.**

- “My **period** is late – I wonder if I’m pregnant?”
- “Stay away from Wendy during that time of the month, she has serious **PMS.**”
- “I need to make a **gyno** appointment this month.”

Your nose contains a substance called mucus, but two slang words for it are **snot** and **boogers.** A slang word for a pimple is a **zit,** and another undesirable bodily trait is to have **BO** – body odor, the bad smell when someone doesn’t use deodorant or bathe regularly.

- “I sneezed so hard that **snot** went all over my face.”
- “This new facial wash really helped clear up my **zits.**”
- “The guy who sat next to me on the bus had horrible **BO** and I could hardly breathe.”

Finally, we have a number of slang phrases for death. These expressions are usually used when *joking* about death; they are insensitive and NOT meant to be used in a situation when somebody's really sad about the death of a loved one (a nicer, more polite way to say "died" is **passed away**). Slang expressions for death include:

- **croak** (v.)
*"He hates shopping for clothes. He'll probably keep wearing the exact same jeans and T-shirt until he **croaks**."*
- **meet your maker** (v.)
*In movies, when a person is threatening to kill someone, they sometimes say "Prepare to **meet your maker**!"*
- **kick the bucket** (v.) / **buy the farm** (v.)
*Some people have what's called a "bucket list" – a list of goals/experiences they want to accomplish before they die: "I definitely want to travel the world before I **kick the bucket**."*
- **six feet under** / **pushing up daisies**
(adj. – to describe someone who has died and is buried)
*"Why should I care about what happens 100 years in the future? I'll be **pushing up daisies** by then."*

Slang Words for Feelings & Senses

Let's start with the slang about sleeping. When you are tired, you are **beat, bushed, pooped, wiped**, or **zonked**. Sometimes your body may be OK, but you're mentally tired – when this happens, you can say your **brain is fried**.

- "It's been a long day. I'm **beat**!"
- "We had so many travel problems that by the end of our vacation we were totally **wiped** instead of relaxed."
- "I've been studying for the past ten hours and **my brain is fried**."

You can take a **catnap** (a very short nap) in the middle of the day, otherwise you might find yourself **dozing off / nodding off** (starting to fall asleep) at dinner!

- "My history professor is so boring that I always start to **doze off** in his class."

A few slang words for going to bed at night are **hit the hay** and **hit the sack**. If you **sleep like a log** or **sleep like a baby**, it means you sleep deeply, soundly and peacefully. Another expression for deep sleep is to say someone **"is out like a light"** – *completely* unconscious and not easy to wake the person up. But if you **toss and turn**, then you DIDN'T sleep well – you kept changing position and not feeling comfortable.

- "It's almost midnight – definitely time to **hit the sack!**"
- "The bed was so comfortable. I **slept like a baby.**"
- "By the end of the movie, my five-year-old daughter was **out like a light**. We had to carry her back to the car."
- "I was so nervous before my interview, I **tossed and turned** the night before."

Have you ever had a day when you couldn't seem to focus, concentrate, or participate fully in your activities, because your mind is somewhere else? When this happens, you can say **"I'm really out of it today."**

Sometimes this lack of focus only lasts a quick moment – when this happens (your mind temporarily goes blank) you can say you **spaced out**. Other times you are trying to remember or say some piece of information that's really obvious, and should easily come to mind, but it doesn't. This is playfully called a **"brain fart"** because it's like your brain temporarily malfunctioned.

- "Huh? What did you say? Sorry – I **spaced out** for a moment there."
- "I'm having a **brain fart** – what was the name of that movie we saw a few days ago?"

On the other hand, when you suddenly understand something, you can say **it clicked:**

- "I spent hours trying to figure out how to solve the problem, until **it clicked** – I realized I was focusing on the wrong issue."

Most of the information we receive comes from our eyes, and we have a number of informal expressions related to seeing:

- If you **keep your eyes peeled** for something, it means you're watching carefully to find something. When driving to a new place and trying to find a particular road, you might tell the other people in the car **"Keep your eyes peeled** for Sunrise Street; I'm not sure if it's on the left or on the right."

- When there's a traffic accident, people driving by in passing cars often slow down and try to see what's going on. This is called **rubbernecking** (because it's like they're stretching their necks out the window to see the accident).
- If you **give someone/something the once-over**, it means you quickly look at them in order to make a fast examination/judgment (but you don't look carefully or in a detailed way): "The doctor was so busy he just **gave me the once-over** and moved on to the next patient."
- A slang word for sunglasses is **shades**, and a slang word for regular glasses is **specs** (although this word can also be short for "specifications").

Slang words for emotions include:

- **"I'm pumped!" / "I'm psyched!" / "I'm stoked!"** = I'm excited for something in the future. **"I'm pumped** for our mountain biking trip this weekend!"
- Someone who is **happy as a clam, walking on air**, or **on cloud nine** is very happy. "She loves her new job; she's been **happy as a clam** ever since she started working there."
- We also have the expression **a happy camper** to describe someone who is happy and satisfied. This expression is often used in the negative, if someone is upset: "Our boss just found out that the project will be delayed yet again. He's **not a happy camper** right now."
- Other informal ways to say someone is sad is to say they're **bummed**, (usually more brief, temporary), **in a funk, have got the blues**, or are **down in the dumps** (this last one is the most intense). "I was kinda **bummed** that it rained and the festival was canceled." (temporarily feeling sad) / "I've been **in a funk** lately; I just can't seem to get excited about anything." (more prolonged sadness)
- Saying someone is a **wreck** means he or she is completely broken down physically, mentally, or emotionally. "Tracy was a **wreck** after finding out her husband had been having an affair with her sister."

- To be **gung ho** is to be very enthusiastic about action/work: “Everyone’s all **gung ho** about their New Year’s resolutions in January, but within a month they’ve usually forgotten all about them.”
- If you **get a kick out of [something]**, it means you enjoy it or find it amusing. This is usually experiencing a quick “flash” of enjoyment: “I **got a kick out of** the main character in the movie – she reminded me of you.”
- If you’re **pissed / pissed off**, you are angry. A less offensive version of this is **ticked / ticked off**. “My brother was **pissed** when he found out the bank had been charging him an extra \$50 fee every month.”
- When someone “explodes” in anger, they **flip out, go ballistic, lose their cool, have a meltdown, throw a hissy fit, snap**, or **have a cow**.
*“When they announced that the fight was canceled, one of the passengers **flipped out** and started screaming at the attendant.”*
*“She’s the calmest person I know; I’ve never seen her **lose her cool** even in very stressful situations.”*
*“When my brother made the same stupid comment for the fifth time, I **snapped** and told him to shut the hell up.”*
- If you’re **on edge**, you’re nervous, like any little thing might make you panic.
*“I’ve been **on edge** ever since I was robbed at gunpoint while walking home from class.”*
- When something **gives you the creeps/willies/heebe-jeebies**, it makes you frightened, anxious, or uncomfortable – especially when there is not a direct, specific reason for the feeling, just a general sense of fear and unease.
*“Let’s get outta here. This dark old house **gives me the creeps**.”*

Slang Words for Money

A few general slang words for money are **dough** and **moolah**, and “dollars” are often called **bucks**:

- “I’ve got a side job to make a little extra **moolah**.”
- “This T-shirt costs 15 **bucks**.”

For talking about multiples of a thousand dollars, we often say it like this:

- \$7,000 = seven thousand dollars
= seven **grand**
= \$7K (seven **K**)

Salaries in the U.S. are often calculated yearly and written with “K” – someone who makes \$48K earns \$48,000 per year.

When someone is rich, you can say the person is **loaded** or **filthy rich** (very rich). Although the word “filthy” also means “very dirty,” this expression doesn’t mean the person got their money in a dishonest way... it just means they are extremely rich.

- “Man, the Johnsons are **loaded** – they collect luxury cars for fun.”

Other expressions for a rich person include saying they **have deep pockets** or are **rolling in dough** (like someone has so much money, they don’t even know what to do with it all). The highest economic class in a country/society can be called the **upper crust**.

- “Amanda’s been **rolling in dough** ever since she sold her company for 5 million.”
- “The **upper crust** isn’t happy about the tax increase for people making over \$250,000 a year.”

To make a lot of money (through work, investing, sales, etc.) is to **make a killing**. When you do something that gives sudden success and riches, this is called **hitting pay dirt**. Some rich people like to show off their wealth with a lot of **bling** – this is a hip-hop slang word for flashy jewelry/decoration.

- “Brad **made a killing** by investing in Apple Computers 20 years ago.”
- “Sophie published book after unsuccessful book until **hitting pay dirt** with her latest novel, which sold millions of copies.”

- “She thought her outfit needed a little more **bling**, so she put on a gold necklace and bracelet.”

If you don't have any money available, you are **broke, hard up**, or **strapped for cash**. You might have to ask your friends to **spot you** some money (lend you money).

- “The worst thing about being **broke** is turning down invitations to go out to eat with friends, since I can't afford the restaurant.”
- “I'm always **strapped for cash** in December after shopping for Christmas gifts for my whole family.”
- “Could you **spot me** a couple hundred dollars until the end of the month?”

Maybe you have a job that **pays peanuts** – this means it pays extremely little money. When you need to live on very little money in order to buy something very expensive, you **pinch pennies** or **scrimp and save**.

- “This internship is a good experience, but it **pays peanuts**. I sure hope I can get a better job soon.”
- “My grandparents **scrumped and saved** for ten years in order to save up enough money to buy a house.”

Finally, a “budget” is a plan for how to spend your money – both people and companies can have budgets. A budget that has very little money available is called a **shoestring budget**.

- “I don't know how the boss expects us to do a big publicity campaign; he's given us a **shoestring budget**.”
-

Slang for Spending/Using Money

If something is overpriced – more expensive than it should be – you can call it a **rip-off**. If popcorn costs \$1 outside the movie theater and \$6 inside the theater, you can say:

- “Man, movie theater popcorn is such a **rip-off!**”

When a price is MUCH higher than it should be, yet it must be paid and you don't have any other options, you can say it's **highway robbery**. For example, if you want

to take an English exam and the administrative fee just to take the exam is \$400, you could say:

- “That’s **highway robbery!**”

Have you ever wanted to buy something, but then felt very surprised and disappointed by the high price? This is called **sticker shock** – like you were shocked when you saw the sticker or tag with the price. If you pay a lot of money for it anyway, then you **pay through the nose** or **pay an arm and a leg**.

- “I checked out prices for the newest iPad and got some **sticker shock** – it’s over a thousand dollars.”
- “My sister is obsessed with her looks; she **pays an arm and a leg** for the top cosmetics and beauty treatments.”
(*pay an arm and a leg is usually for things you WANT to buy*)
- “After the accident I had to **pay through the nose** to get my car repaired.”
(*pay through the nose is usually for things you are being forced or required to buy, which are extremely expensive*)

When you spend most of your money on something, so that it leaves you with very little money available, you **blow your money** on it. This expression usually implies spending on things that are luxuries or wastes of money.

- “He won the lottery, but then **blew** all the money on alcohol and drugs and ended up completely broke within three years.”

On the opposite end of the spectrum, something that is very inexpensive can be described as **dirt cheap** or **a steal**. You can buy it **without breaking the bank** – without using up all your money. Even better is **a freebie** – something you receive for free.

- “These T-shirts are **dirt cheap** – 3 shirts for \$10!”
- “In order to take a vacation **without breaking the bank**, we stayed at a friend’s house instead of a hotel.”
- “When you buy a computer at that store, they throw in a couple of **freebies** like an extra charger and a pair of headphones.”

Let’s imagine you’re at a restaurant with your friend. If you **pick up the tab**, it means you pay for everything – both your meal and your friend’s. To tell your friend that you’re going to do this, you can say, **“This is on me.”** This expression can be used anytime you are paying for someone else’s part – in restaurants, bars, paying

for tickets, or anything else. However, your friend might not want to let you pay – maybe he'll suggest **splitting** the bill **50-50** (dividing it equally).

Here are three expressions for actions with money that are not so honest:

- If you **grease someone's palm**, it means you give them a bribe (money secretly given in exchange for a special favor)
*"I think that company must have **greased a few palms** in the government in order to get special legal benefits."*
- A **kickback** is a portion of money received back from a transaction, often in a secret or illegal agreement
*"The drug lord has a team of drug dealers and he gets a **kickback** from each sale they make."*
- Although this isn't technically illegal, some companies **nickel and dime** their customers with small extra fees and charges, which is annoying because the amount can add up!
*"The basic cell phone plan is pretty cheap, but then they **nickel and dime** you because SMS, internet, and insurance each cost extra."*

Slang for Food, Drink, & Drugs

Some slang words for food in general are **grub** and **chow**. These are usually used in the informal phrase: "Let's get some **grub/chow**" when you want to get food together with your friends.

The word **nosh** means snack-type food, not a complete meal. It can also be used as a verb: "She's **noshing on** potato chips." If you **have the munchies** (have light hunger, desire for snack food) you can nosh on cookies, nuts, etc.

The word **brunch** is a combination of *breakfast + lunch*: it is a mid-morning meal (eaten around 10:30) that takes the place of breakfast and lunch. Some churches and social groups like to organize brunches on weekends.

When you don't eat all your food at a restaurant, and you want to take the leftovers home, you take them home in a **doggy bag**. You can put the leftovers in the

refrigerator and then **nuke** them (heat them up in the microwave) when you want to eat them later.

When we're *extremely* hungry, we often exaggerate and say **"I'm starving!"** – and after you've eaten too much, you can say **"I'm stuffed!"** The regular expression is "I'm full," but "stuffed" means you've eaten too much and no more food will fit into your stomach.

Someone who really likes sweet and sugary foods like candy, cookies, ice cream, etc. **has a sweet tooth**; and someone who has a more healthy diet will eat more **veggies** (short for "vegetables.")

Now let's look at drinks. Most of the slang for drinking revolves around alcohol, but there is one informal word for a cup of coffee: **cup o' joe** (sometimes spelled **cuppa joe**): "I can't concentrate in the morning until I've had a nice, strong **cuppa joe**."

Imagine it's a really hot summer day, and you **take a swig of** (take a big drink of) an ice-cold lemonade – you could say **"Ahhh, that hits the spot!"** The expression "that hits the spot" means "that was satisfying; that was exactly what I wanted." It can be used about any type of drink that you really wanted.

The word **booze** is slang for alcohol. On some party invitations, there's the abbreviation BYOB, which means "bring your own booze" – the guests will need to bring alcohol to the party. Some people like to **pregame** – drink at home or at someone's house before going to the main party/event of the night.

If you prefer to go out, you can **bar hop** – go from bar to bar, spending only a short time at each. Sometimes a popular local bar is called a **watering hole**, because it attracts people like a pool of water attracts thirsty animals. At the bar, someone should check your **ID** (identification) at the door to be sure you are old enough to drink.

- "Murphy's is the only **watering hole** in town that has decent beer."
- "Can I see some **ID**, please?"
- "The teenagers tried to get into the bar using fake **IDs**."

There are dozens of slang words that mean someone is drunk. If you are **buzzed** or **have a buzz**, it means you are only a little bit drunk. Describing someone as a **lightweight** means they get drunk easily; it only takes a little bit of alcohol to affect them.

- “He finds it much easier to talk to pretty girls when he’s **buzzed**.”
- “She’s such a **lightweight** that she can’t have more than one glass of wine.”

Someone who is *completely* drunk is **hammered, sloshed, plastered**, or **wasted**. One funny way to describe someone who is drunk is to say they are **three sheets to the wind** – this refers to a sailboat with nobody controlling its sails (“sheets”).

- “Rick is **plastered**, he shouldn’t drive home. Let’s call a taxi for him.”
- “Ashley always makes hilarious comments when she’s **three sheets to the wind**.”

One slang word for someone who is an alcoholic, or who drinks too much, is a **lush**:

- “My ex-husband was such a **lush** that he’d even bring a water bottle full of vodka to work, so he could drink secretly during the day.”

The word “wasted” can also be used for someone who is completely under the influence of drugs. Speaking of drugs, we have:

- **coke** – cocaine
- **crack** – a more pure form of cocaine
- **pot / weed / grass / herb** – marijuana
- **a joint** – a marijuana cigarette
- **acid** – LSD (a psychedelic drug that causes hallucinations)
- **E / X** – ecstasy (a drug that causes euphoria, often used in dance parties)
- **speed / meth** – methamphetamine (a drug that causes increased energy)

The period of intense feelings caused by the drug is called a **high**, and this word can also be used to describe a person currently under the influence of drugs: “He’s **high**.”

When a drug causes hallucinations and crazy psychological experiences, that is a **trip** and the person is “**tripping**.” Of course, after the high/trip, the drug user experiences a **crash**: a sudden drop in energy and mood.

One slang word for people who are addicted to drugs is a **junkie**, although there are also some more specific words like **pothead / stoner** (someone who smokes a lot of marijuana) and **cokehead** (someone addicted to cocaine).

- “There are a few **junkies** living under the highway bridge.”

- “My college roommate was a **stoner**; I was always nervous that I’d get in trouble, too, if he was caught with weed in our room.”

Some drug users try to quit **cold turkey** – that means stopping suddenly, resolving never to use the drug again. You can also quit smoking cold turkey; this expression can be used for any addictive habit where you stop instantly (instead of gradually decreasing).

College Slang

If you get a **full ride** to college, it means you get a 100% scholarship – your studies are paid for, so you can study for free. A student can get a **full ride** because of their academic accomplishments, their athletic potential, or because they or their family is poor.

- “Samantha was the top student in her high school class and got a **full ride** to college.”

In the U.S., most college students live in a **dorm** (short for dormitory) and the outdoor area in the middle of the dorms is the **quad**. When you first go to college, watch out for the **freshman 15** – the tendency to gain 15 pounds in your first year at college (first-year students are called “freshmen”).

- “This is a women’s-only **dorm**, but that other **dorm** over there is mixed-gender.”
- “It’s a sunny day, so a lot of people are playing frisbee and sunbathing out on the **quad**.”
- “When I came back home for summer vacation, my mother said I should work out more to lose the **freshman 15**.”

Some colleges have special, selective social groups – for men, they are called a fraternity or **frat**, and for women, they are a sorority. **Frat parties** are parties thrown by a fraternity.

If you **slack off** (be lazy, not do the work/study) during the semester, you’ll have to **cram** (study very hard) the night before the final exam. One way to say you’re going to study is “**I’m gonna hit the books.**” You might even need to **pull an all-nighter**: stay awake the entire night studying or working on a project. The next day, make sure to **catch some Z’s** (get some sleep) so that you’re not completely exhausted.

- “I’ve been **slacking off** in my literature class... I’ve only done about half the required reading.”
- “I can’t go out tonight; gotta **cram** for my biology final!” (*final = final exam*)
- “I **pulled an all-nighter** to prepare my presentation. Hopefully I can **catch some Z’s** later this afternoon.”

When a teacher gives a surprise quiz in class that he/she didn’t tell you about earlier, this is called a **pop quiz**. If you **ace** a quiz or test, it means you got a very good grade.

- “I was totally unprepared for the **pop quiz** today since I hadn’t been to class for the past week!”
- “The extra help from my tutor was what really helped me **ace** the math test.”

College students in their final year are called “seniors,” and some seniors experience **senioritis** – a type of laziness because you’re nearing the end of your studies. They might **cut class** (not go to class) or not put much effort into their academic work.

- “A lot of students **cut class** on Friday afternoons, especially when it’s a sunny day.”

If they’re not careful, they might **flunk** a test/course (get a failing grade) or even **flunk out** – fail so many courses that they do not meet the minimum standards, and must leave the school.

- “I eventually decided a career in science wasn’t for me after **flunking** chemistry three times in college.”

Click here for more college slang: <http://blog.peertransfer.com/2013/01/28/how-to-keep-up-with-american-college-slang/>

Slang Words for Work & Business

A job in which you work typical business hours is often called **a 9 to 5**. When you work at another job, a side job, in addition to your regular full-time job, this is called **moonlighting**. An informal job – usually for musicians – is called a **gig**.

- “The director of marketing at our company **moonlights** as a chef – I’ve heard his restaurant is actually getting pretty successful!”
- “Our band has played a few **gigs** in local bars and nightclubs.”

A few professions have slang nicknames – a police officer is a **cop**; a taxi driver is a **cabbie**; people who work for the federal government can be called **the feds**; and a person who works at a bar/nightclub to expel people who are problematic or who start fights is a **bouncer**.

- “Three people were injured by stray bullets in the shootout between the gang members and the **cops**.”
- “If you paid \$40, the **cabbie** definitely overcharged you – the ride from the airport to the city center should only be about \$28.”
- “**The feds** have been investigating this human trafficking ring for years, and now they finally have enough information to make an arrest.”
- “Some of the guys at the bar were getting too rowdy, and the **bouncer** threw them out.”

An accountant can be called a **number cruncher**, and the expression “crunch the numbers” in general means to do calculations. Someone who works at a desk job, mainly with paperwork, can be called a **paper pusher**. (Both of these expressions can also be used as verbs, as in the following examples):

- “We’re not sure yet if we can afford to buy the new equipment. We need to **crunch the numbers** (= *do the calculations*).”
- “I feel like my job is meaningless, all I do is **push papers** all day.”
(= *do boring administrative paperwork*)

When you start your career, you’ll often be the **low man on the totem pole** – the least important and lowest-ranking member of the group or company. When you’re a **small fry** (an unimportant person), you’ll need to **pay your dues** – do the hard, unpleasant work in order to earn more power and success. You may need to do a lot of **grunt work** (hard work that is not very interesting), and the **daily grind** (difficult daily life) probably won’t be so enjoyable.

- “I’m the **low man on the totem pole**, so I don’t have any decision-making power in the company.”
- “Relax, you’ll be promoted eventually – but you need to **pay your dues** first.”
- “My coworker always volunteers for the fun projects, leaving me with all the **grunt work**.”
- “Some companies decorate their offices in an effort to make the **daily grind** less depressing.”

Hopefully you'll get your career onto the **fast track** (the fastest and most direct route to success) and become one of the **top dogs** (the most powerful/important people) at your company. The top dogs often get a lot of **perks** (special benefits) at their jobs, such as a company car or travel that is paid for by the company.

- "Networking with other professionals can help **fast track** your career – your contacts might help you get a better job opportunity at another company."
- "The decision about the project hasn't been made yet. The **top dogs** are still debating about it."
- "Managers and directors at my company get a few extra **perks** like extra sick days and double pay for overtime."

Another slang word for important and powerful people is **bigwigs**. These are the people who **call the shots** (make the decisions) and give everyone else their **marching orders** (instructions for tasks). Inside a company/organization, important announcements are often communicated through **memos** (short for memorandums – short and informative notes).

- "I'm so glad I went to that conference; I got to meet some of the **bigwigs** in the manufacturing industry."
- "I can't sign any advertising contracts; you need to talk to my supervisor because she's the one who **calls the shots**."
- "During the meeting, the team leader gave each of us our **marching orders** so that we all knew who was responsible for which tasks."
- "The company vice-president just sent an e-mail **memo** that the office will be closed tomorrow because of the heavy snowstorm in the forecast."

A person who always says "yes" to their superiors, and does whatever the superiors want without questioning it or suggesting anything different, is a **yes man**. Another sneaky way to make your superiors like you is to **brownnose** – flatter and try to get their favor.

- "Alan has some really innovative ideas for revolutionizing the business, but then he just turns into a **yes man** whenever he's around the company president."
- "She's completely unqualified for the position of vice-president; she only got it because of **brownnosing**."

If you, as a subordinate, challenge or disrespect the bigwigs, then you are **out of line** (acting inappropriately based on the hierarchy). You might **get the axe** or **be sacked** (be fired; lose your job).

- “I don’t mind you correcting me, but you were **out of line** when you did so rudely in front of other employees.”
- “Oliver **was sacked** after his boss discovered he’d been surfing the net all day instead of working.”

After getting sacked, maybe you want to start your own company. Working for yourself is a great way to escape the **rat race** (the competitive corporate environment where it’s difficult to succeed) if you can get past all the **red tape** (excessive bureaucracy) to open your own business.

- “My mother is retiring next year; she says she’s looking forward to getting out of the **rat race**.”
- “Opening a café isn’t so simple – you have to get a license to serve food, an inspection from the health department, and there’s just a lot of **red tape** in general.”

It’s great if you can find an **angel investor**, a rich person or successful businessman who can lend you the initial money to start up your business. But if you can’t find one, you’ll have to **bootstrap** – start the company with very little money, spending only on what is absolutely necessary, until it grows.

- “The new computer company attracted a lot of funding from **angel investors** because of its innovative ideas, which could have a big impact in the market.”
- “After seven years of **bootstrapping** my landscaping business, I’m happy to say it has finally reached a healthy level of profit.”

When you have your own business, you’ll need to know **the nitty-gritty** (the specific, practical details) and do much of the **legwork** (the practical work, not just the strategizing) yourself. To succeed, you’ll have to **go for broke** – put in 100% of your effort and risk everything in order to achieve your goal. Just be careful not to become a **workaholic** – someone who’s addicted to their work and who works too much.

- “We don’t have time to go into **the nitty-gritty** on this phone call, but I’ll send you an e-mail with a complete report.”

- “I’d like to thank my assistant Eric, who has done a lot of the **legwork** for this project.”
- “Don’t hold back from following your dreams. **Go for broke!**”
- “A lot of Americans are such **workaholics** that they don’t even take all the vacation days available to them.”

Maybe your new company will find a **cash cow** – a product that provides a steady source of profits – and become established in the marketplace. If you were the one who invented the idea/product, it is your **brainchild**. If your product is promising, you can run advertising campaigns to **turbocharge** (dramatically improve/increase) your sales.

- “The company sells a whole line of clothing and fashion accessories, but its expensive, high-quality shoes are its real **cash cow**.”
- “Windows was the **brainchild** of Microsoft, and it changed computing forever.”
- “The English school is adding extra activities to the course in order to **turbocharge** the students’ learning.”

Now let’s imagine that your startup company has grown **like gangbusters** (fast and with lots of energy), and it is now so successful that other companies want to form partnerships and agreements with you.

- “The popularity of this smartphone app is growing **like gangbusters** among teenagers.”

If you’re an especially aggressive negotiator you’ll **play hardball** – take a very firm, uncompromising stand in order to achieve your objectives. When you do decide to make a deal, definitely read all the **legalese** (difficult legal language used in contracts) in the contract, so you know what you’re getting into!

- “We offered 1.5 million to buy the building, but the owner is **playing hardball** – he absolutely refuses to sell us the property for anything less than two million.”
- “I can’t stand it when I have to sign a document that’s full of **legalese**; I’m always afraid I won’t completely understand what I’m agreeing to.”

Slang for Sex

A **player** is a man who likes to date / have sex with many different women without making a commitment (this action is also called “playing the field”). This term has a negative connotation, as it implies he is being manipulative and only using women for the sex. Another unpleasant slang word for a man who is very aggressive about pursuing women is a **skirt chaser**. A less negative word for a man who is attractive and popular with women is to say he is a **ladies’ man**.

- “He’s really hot, but a total **player** – he’s with a different girl practically every week.”
- “Danny was shy and awkward as a teenager, but when he grew up he became quite the **ladies’ man**.”

Three derogatory words for a woman who has many sexual partners are **slut**, **tramp**, and **whore**. “Whore” is also slang for a prostitute, who can also be called a **hooker**.

- “My father’s really religious and doesn’t approve of mini-skirts, he says they make me look like a **slut**.”
- “The senator resigned after the scandal in which his wife found him in a hotel room with three **hookers**.”

A woman with very strong sexual desire and frequent sexual activity is a **nympho** (short for “nymphomaniac”) – this word can have a positive or negative connotation depending on the context. And a **cock-tease** is a derogatory slang term for a woman who acts in a sexual way, but without fulfilling a man’s sexual desire.

An older woman who pursues sexual relationships with younger men is a **cougar**, and the young man is her **boy toy**. Having a sexual relationship with someone much younger than yourself in general is called **robbing the cradle**. (Both men and women can “rob the cradle”). A person (usually a girl) who is attractive/sexually desirable, but who is below the legal age of consent, is called **jailbait**.

Calling a person **eye candy** means they are nice to look at, and someone who is **arm candy** is an attractive person who accompanies someone to an event, but is not romantically involved with that person.

Some rich older men marry a **trophy wife**, an attractive young woman (the term implies that he only considers her a “prize” for his success). The rich older man can be called a **sugar daddy** – someone who gives expensive gifts to a young woman in return for companionship or sex. A woman who specifically seeks out a rich man is called a **gold-digger**. This implies that she doesn’t care about the man’s personality, only about his wealth.

- “After he became famous for his art, he married a **trophy wife** young enough to be his granddaughter.”
- “Clara’s just looking for a **sugar daddy**; she doesn’t care what he does for a living or how he treats her.”
- “It’s hard to date when you start becoming successful in your career – my past three girlfriends turned out to be nothing but **gold-diggers**.”

There are many derogatory slang words for people who are homosexual, such as **fag** / **faggot** and **fairy** for homosexual men, and **dyke** for a homosexual woman. **Tranny** is an offensive word for a transvestite, transgendered, or transsexual person.

WARNING: these terms are insulting! I am only teaching them so you can understand them if you hear them in movies or on TV.

The acceptable terms are **gay** (usually for a homosexual man, though sometimes used for women as well), **lesbian** (specifically for a homosexual woman), and **bi** (for a bisexual person). A few euphemisms for a bisexual person is to say they’re a **switch hitter** or they **swing both ways**.

- “I struggled to understand my sexual orientation for a long time, until finally accepting the fact that I’m **bi**.”
- “My best friend is **gay**. He and his partner have been together for twelve years.” (*“partner” is often used for members of gay/lesbian relationships*)
- “My family knows I’m a **lesbian**, but most of my colleagues at work don’t.”

Although some members of the homosexual community use the word **queer** to describe people with non-heterosexual orientations, this word can be considered offensive if used by someone outside this group; it can also be used as an insult depending on tone of voice. A heterosexual person is called **straight**.

When a homosexual person has not yet revealed his/her sexual orientation to friends/family, the person is said to be **closeted** or **in the closet**. The process of revealing one’s sexual orientation to other people is called **coming out**.

- “**Coming out** was very hard for my daughter, but I reassured her that I love her the same no matter what her sexual orientation is.”
- “Although that actor has a wife and children, a lot of people think he’s secretly **in the closet** because of the way he acts.”

The range of slang terms and euphemisms for kissing, masturbation, and sex is enormous; so here I’ll just summarize a few of the most common terms. When two people are kissing very intensely, they are **making out, going at it**, or **all over each other**. A mark left on someone’s neck due to kissing/sucking by their lover is a **hickey** or a **love bite**.

- “A couple of teenagers sitting in front of me at the movie theater were **making out** the whole time, it was so distracting!”

An erection of the penis can be called a **boner, hard-on**, or **woody**, and when a woman is sexually aroused, we say she is **wet**. When a man has a hard-on, but then does not have sex or get sexual satisfaction, he ends up with **blue balls** – pain in the region of the testicles due to the accumulation of unreleased fluid.

Masturbation (stimulating yourself sexually) has *hundreds* of slang terms and euphemisms, and people make up new ones all the time. A few of the most common are **wank, fap, jack off, wack off, rub one out, beat the meat, spank the monkey** (for men), and **flick the bean** (for women).

Films that show explicit sex are called pornography, usually **porn** for short. Another informal way to refer to a pornographic movie is a **skin flick**.

Someone who wants to have sex is **horny** or **randy**, and slang verbs for sexual intercourse itself include **bang, bone, screw, fuck, bump uglies, get some action, get some ass/tail, do it**, and **do the nasty**.

When someone manages to have a sexual encounter (especially when they were wanting/trying to), you could say they **scored** or **got laid**. To describe someone’s sexual ability, you can say they are **good in bed / bad in bed** (or, less commonly, **a good/bad lay**). Sexual adventures/encounters can be described as **sexcapades** (sex + escapade).

A short, fast sexual encounter is a **quickie**, and there are many slang terms for specific sexual acts. Oral sex on a man can be called a **blow job** (or **BJ**), and for giving oral sex to a woman, this is **going down on her** or **eating her out**.

Sexual acts or preferences that are deviant from the “normal” can be described as **kinky**. Some people enjoy using sex toys, such as an artificial penis, which is called a **dildo**.

There are various names for different sexual positions, but three of the most common are:

- The **missionary position**: the “typical” position where the man and the woman lie facing each other, with the man on top
- **Doggy-style**: The woman is on her hands and knees, and the man is behind her.
- **69**: When the man and woman give each other oral sex simultaneously.

The moment of sexual climax is officially called orgasm, but some people call it “**the big O**” and arriving at that point is to **cum** or (less explicitly) to **finish**. When a man releases semen, this can be called **blowing his load/wad**, and the semen itself can be called **cum** or **jizz**.

Slang Words for Relationships

A few of the most common affectionate names that people in a romantic relationship call each other are: **babe, baby, honey, sweetheart, sweetie, sugar, dear, darling**. The last two are slightly older words, and are sometimes used outside the context of a romantic relationship as well.

- Inside a relationship: “I love you, **baby**.”
- Outside a relationship (man talking to attractive woman at a bar): “Hey **baby**, can I buy you a drink?”
- Parent to child (usually honey, sweetheart, sweetie): “No, **sweetie**, you can’t have a snack right now – we’ll be having dinner soon.”
- Old woman to young woman: “Could you help me carry these bags, **dear**?”

A short, casual relationship ranging from a few days to a few months is a **fling**. Even shorter than that is a **hookup** or **one-night stand**, when you have sex with someone for only one night.

- “Oh, Bobby was never really my boyfriend. We just had a **fling** over the summer, nothing serious.”

- “Patricia called off the wedding after she found out that Steve had **hooked up** with one of his ex-girlfriends.”

Some people hook up with a person they’ve just met in a bar – sometimes because they’re wearing **“beer goggles”** (this refers to the fact that when you’re drunk, other people appear more sexually attractive than they really are).

When two people are dating and in a committed relationship, you can say they are **an item**. An affectionate way to refer to your romantic partner is as your **better half**. Women also sometimes refer to their husbands as their **hubby**.

- “After years of friendship, it looks like Frank and Michelle are now officially **an item**.”
- “I’d like you to meet **my better half** – this is my wife, Joanna.”

A slang word for the action of breaking up with someone is to **dump** the person. This implies that one person wanted to end the relationship, but the other person didn’t. A previous romantic partner can be called an **ex**. This can be used for ex-husbands, ex-wives, ex-boyfriends, and ex-girlfriends.

- “Can you believe Evan **dumped** Erica by text message?! What a spineless clod!” (*clod = stupid and insensitive person*)
- “I’m still in touch with my **ex**, we occasionally exchange e-mails to see how each other is doing – but there’s no chance of getting back together.”

Someone who was a romantic interest or partner from many years ago is an **old flame**. If you have emotional problems/issues from past relationships or experiences, then you have **baggage**.

- “My wife wasn’t happy when an **old flame** of mine moved back into town.”
- “Angela has lots of **baggage** after breaking up with her last boyfriend, who was rather manipulative.”

Sometimes people start a new relationship *immediately* after ending the old one. This is called being **“on the rebound”** and it usually implies that the new relationship is not genuine, it is just a substitute for the old one, or entered out of desperation.

- “After his divorce from Veronica, Mike married another woman **on the rebound** after only knowing her for two months!”

Some people have alternative relationship structures such as an **“open marriage”** in which both people are free to have other sexual partners. They may even have a **threesome**, a sexual encounter involving three people. Another alternative lifestyle is **swinging**, exchanging sexual partners with other couples. (People who do this are called **swingers**.)

- “Arthur and Tara have very modern ideas about sexuality; they have an **open marriage** in which they can each sleep with other people as long as they’re honest with each other about it.”
- “That town has quite an active community of **swingers**.”

Informal ways to say a woman is pregnant is to say she is **preggers** or **preggo**. There are also the expressions “She has a bun in the oven” and “She’s in the family way.” The expression **knocked up** also means pregnant (or to impregnate) – usually from careless or unwise sexual activity. Sometimes a pregnant woman’s belly is referred to as a **baby bump**.

- “Have you heard the news? Gina is **preggers**!”
- “Teenage girls need to learn about safe sex so they don’t get **knocked up** before graduating from high school.”
- “She’s about six months along and showing off her **baby bump**.”

Slang Words for Fights, Conflict, & Competition

Some people **have a chip on their shoulder** – a bad attitude, meaning they easily get upset or angry. Others **have a short fuse**, meaning it doesn’t take long for them to “explode” with anger. When someone is *trying* to start a fight, we call this **picking a fight**.

- “I support feminism, but I don’t particularly like feminists who **have a chip on their shoulder** and view *everything* as an insult towards women.”
- “Brian is normally pretty laid-back, but he **has a short fuse** while driving – he’ll scream and curse at other drivers who are being slow or stupid.”
- “I don’t really get along with my sister; she’s always **picking fights** with me over the littlest things.”

Some fights start with gestures – for example, if someone **flips you off** or **flips you the bird**, it means they show you their middle finger (considered a very offensive

gesture). Other fights begin with words – some guys might be **messing with** (bothering, teasing) a girl, and her brother tells them, **"Knock it off!"** (stop doing it), and then this escalates into a fight.

- "When a girl asked Russell to please turn down the music, he just **flipped her off** without saying a word."
- "I was a short, skinny, nerdy kid in middle school and the popular kids were always **messing with** me – but I never had the courage to defend myself."

Saying something disrespectful about someone/something is **dissing** them. A similar action is to **talk smack** or **talk trash** – insulting and criticizing, often in an excessive or exaggerated way.

- "The fight started after Jim **dissed** Kyle's mother, and then Kyle threw a punch."
- "The basketball players started **talking smack** about their opponents on the other team."

There are also more direct insults to a specific person:

- **Fuck off! / Piss off!**
(extremely rude ways to say "go away")
- **You're full of shit.**
(extremely rude way to say a person is lying, or you don't believe them)
- **Mind your own damn business!**
(to tell another person to stop interfering in your life/situation. You can also remove the word "damn" to make it less offensive)
- **Go fuck yourself. / Go to hell. / Bite me. / Suck my dick.** *(only men)*
- **You... [asshole/bastard/bitch/dipshit/moron/pussy]**
(direct insults to the other person)

When a fight becomes physical, you can **clock**, **deck**, or **slug** someone – these words all mean to punch the person. To **take a swing at** someone means to try to punch them (usually unsuccessfully).

- "After arguing for ten minutes over who had gotten the seat first, the other guy actually **took a swing at** me!"
- "The athlete was arrested for assault after he **slugged** a reporter who was persistently asking him questions."

If you **kick the person's ass** or **give the person a beatdown/ass whooping**, it means you won the fight, you hurt the other person more than they hurt you. But if you **get your ass kicked / get your ass handed to you**, it means you lost the fight; the other person hurt you worse than you hurt them.

- “Mark is always bragging about the fights he's gotten into; according to him, he always **gives** the other guy **an ass whooping**.”
- “My older brother is much bigger than me, so I'd never start fights with him because I knew I'd **get my ass kicked**.”

During a fight, other people might yell **“Break it up!”** as they try to separate the fighters and stop the fight.

A few slang words for killing someone are to **waste, whack**, or **off** the person, or to **take the person out**. You'll typically see these in movies when criminals or gangsters are talking about killing someone.

- “He knows too much. We've gotta **take him out**.”
- “Al is on the run after **offing** two policemen.”

When talking about fights and sports games, we have numerous slang words for *completely* beating the other person/team, including **whip, thrash, lick, pulverize, slaughter, cream, shellac**, and **wipe the floor with**.

- “We didn't just win the game, we **slaughtered** them – 15 to 2.”
- “I played tennis with my brother and he **shellacked** me – in fact, I didn't score a single point against him!”

Slang Words for Communication

Someone who talks a lot is a **chatterbox**. The verbs **chat** and **gab** are used for an informal conversation, and the verbs **yak** and **yap** also mean talking informally and continuously, but with a connotation that the conversation is annoying.

- “Debbie's a real **chatterbox** – if you're on the phone with her, you'll have to make up an excuse in order to bring the call to an end.”
- “A few of the students stayed after class to **chat** with the teacher.”
- “I don't understand why everyone's **yapping** about the final episode of that reality TV show. Don't they have anything better to do with their time?”

A **blabbermouth** is someone who **blabs** – reveals secret information through careless talk. A blabbermouth is incapable of **keeping something under wraps** (keeping it secret).

- “It was supposed to be a surprise party for Leo, but Kayla **blabbed** about it to Leo’s sister and eventually he found out.”
- “I’m going to be leaving my job in a couple months, but **keep that under wraps** because I haven’t told my supervisors yet, OK?”

A more intentional version of a blabbermouth is a **tattletale** – someone who reports a wrong action to a person in authority. This word is mainly used among children; another word more commonly used by adults is a **snitch** (this can be a noun or a verb).

- “The kids in my daughter’s class called her a **tattletale** when she told the teacher they were copying their homework assignments from the internet.”
- “Some **snitch** told the manager I was playing games on my laptop during a meeting, and now laptops are prohibited in meetings – we have to take notes on paper.”

If someone is **cussing**, it means they are swearing, saying bad words. The expression **“drop an f-bomb”** means to say the word “fuck,” especially in a context where it might not be appropriate/expected. Some people also refer to **four-letter words**, meaning swear words – since some of the most common swears in English (fuck, shit, crap) have four letters.

- “The soccer player was ejected from the game after **cussing** at the referee.”
- “I saw my pastor chatting with a friend on the street, and he **dropped an f-bomb** in the conversation – I wasn’t expecting that!”

When kids **talk back** to their parents, it means they challenge their parents in a disrespectful way. Speaking disrespectfully or rudely to someone is also called **giving some lip**.

- “When I was a teenager, my mom used to take away my computer privileges if I ever **talked back** to her.”
- “I want you to clean your room by the end of the day – and don’t **give me any lip!**”

Here are some slang words for different types of communication:

- To **pull someone's leg** means to be joking, teasing, or kidding.
*"Why is she so upset about my comments? I was just **pulling her leg**."*
- To **bitch about** something is to complain about it in a cranky way.
*"Donna is always **bitching about** how much work she has to do; I wish she would just shut up and actually do the work."*
- To **give someone an earful** is to tell them how angry you are with them.
*"My mother **gave me an earful** when I came home from the club at 3 AM, without calling her to let her know where I was."*
- To give **a pep talk** means giving an enthusiastic speech designed to encourage and motivate people.
*"The company president gave all the employees **a pep talk**, saying that this could be our most profitable year yet if we could all work together as a team."*
- To **sweet talk** someone means to use compliments and flattering words in order to win their favor – usually in order to manipulate them into doing something you want.
*"John tried to **sweet talk** the security guard into letting him into the concert without a ticket, but it didn't work."*
- To **drop a bomb** is to announce shocking or startling news.
*"At Christmas, Jerry **dropped a bomb** – he told the whole family that he was leaving his well-paying job to pursue his dream of becoming an actor."*
- Gossip, especially secret or scandalous information, can be called **dirt**. There's also the expression **the scoop**, which is used for the latest information on news stories, or current information in general.
*"Janet kept asking me questions in order to get all the **dirt** on my brother's recent breakup with his girlfriend."*
*"Read the latest issue of the magazine to get **the scoop** on this winter's fashion trends!"*
- If you **hear something through the grapevine**, you hear it indirectly, not directly from the people involved.

*"No, Betty didn't tell me she's pregnant, but I **heard it through the grapevine**."*

- A **cop-out** is an excuse, especially a weak excuse for evading a responsibility or commitment
*"Saying you don't have enough time is a **cop-out**. Everyone makes time for what's really important to them."*
- A **sob story** is an excessively sentimental story about problems or difficulties, told in order to cause sympathy in the listener.
*"During an interview, never tell a **sob story** about how badly you need the job. The employer doesn't care about your problems; they only want to know if you're qualified to do the work."*
- To **fib** is to tell a small, trivial lie.
*"I know most women over 30 **fib** about their age, but it still bothers me – why can't they just be honest about how old they are?"*
- A **straight answer** is a truthful, direct answer. It's usually used in the negative, when someone won't give you a straight answer (instead they avoid the issue or talk about other details).
*"When I asked Joe about what happened to my book that he borrowed, I couldn't get a **straight answer** out of him. I think he lost it and is afraid to tell me."*
- If you are **up to speed** with a subject or activity, you have all the most current information about it. Often used in the expression "get up to speed" – to catch up on the most recent information.
*"I'm joining the team late, so I need to get **up to speed** on all the details of the project."*
- To keep someone **in the loop** means to keep them updated about something. The opposite, **out of the loop**, can also be used for not knowing or not being involved in something.
*"Please keep me **in the loop** about any changes you plan to make on the website; I'd like to know what's going on."*

- Questioning someone very aggressively is called giving them **the third degree** or **grilling** the person.
*"Dan **grilled** his teenage daughter's boyfriend about where they'd be going and what exactly they planned to do."*
- If you give someone an alert, a notification, or advance information, that is called giving them **a heads-up**.
*"Just wanted to give you **a heads-up** that next Thursday's class will be canceled because it falls on a holiday."*
- If you give someone **the 411** or **the low-down**, you give them information.
*"Let me give you **the low-down** on how this program works."*
- Information that is nonsense or not true can be called **bunk**, **bullshit**, **bull**, **baloney**, **rubbish**, **hogwash**, or **malarkey**. Often used in the phrase "That's a load of..."
*"Personally, I think religion is a load of **bunk**. People just want to believe in something that makes them feel good, even if it has no basis in fact."*
*"Oh, you stayed home last night? **Bullshit!** I saw you at the bar with Theresa."*
*"Most of the promises that politicians make are just **hogwash**. They just want to get elected; they never do anything they promised during the campaign."*
- One slang verb for complaining and whining is **bellyaching**, and having a complaint or problem with someone/something can be called having some **beef** or a **bone to pick with** [the person/organization responsible].
*"Stop **bellyaching** about how bad things are in this country. Either do something to change it, or leave."*
*"I've got some **beef** with my son's baseball coach – he's a great player, but I think he encourages the boys to be too competitive."*
- To **bash** or **slam** something is to criticize it intensely.
*"You're the most close-minded person I know; you're always **bashing** people who have different opinions, and you won't even listen to them."*
*"The media **slammed** the singer's decision to leave the band, saying he was selfish for wanting to pursue a solo career."*

- A word for an anonymous, unspecified person is **so-and-so**.
*"All my coworkers love celebrity gossip and are always talking about how **so-and-so** got a divorce or had an affair. I couldn't care less."*
- Slang words for an object that you don't know the name of include **thingy**, **thingamajig**, **doodad**, **doohickey**, and **gizmo** (this last one usually for a mechanical/electronic device).
*"The machine is broken – this **thingy** (=part of the machine that I don't know the name of) somehow got disconnected, and I'm not sure how to fix it."*
*"This handy little **gizmo** allows you to get TV reception on your cell phone."
(handy = convenient)*

Other Informal Communication Phrases:

- **What gives?** = What's the problem?
*"Hey, my password for my online bank account's not working. **What gives?**"*
- **What's with...?** = What's going on with...?
*"**What's with** Martha? She seems like she's mad at me... or is she just having a bad day?"*
- **Okey dokey** = OK
- **Don't knock it.** = Don't say bad things about it
*Situation: Someone is making fun of country music, but you like some country singers, you can say "Hey, **don't knock it**. There are actually some great singers in country music."*
- **I'm all ears.** = I'm listening, and eager to hear what you have to say
*Situation: You've been unemployed for a long time, and your friend mentions a job opportunity where you could work only 4 hours a day but make a good salary. You'd say "**I'm all ears!**" because you definitely want to hear about it.*
- **Beats me.** = I have no idea how/why; it doesn't make sense to me
*"Why do some people stay in relationships in which they're miserable? **Beats me**. In my opinion, they'd be better off single and happy."*

- **No biggie / No worries.** = It's not difficult, it's not a problem.
"Sorry I didn't bring enough worksheets for everyone in the group."
"No biggie, I'll just share with my friend or make a copy later."
- **Sweet! / Awesome! / Right on!** = A positive response; that's great
"My company is sending me to a conference on a tropical island – all expenses paid."
"Sweet!"
- **Bingo.** = You're exactly right
"We're losing money because it costs a lot to manufacture the product, yet we're selling it at a very low price."
"Bingo."
- **Hell no! / Hell yeah/yes!** = A way to add enthusiasm/emphasis to no/yes
"Would you ever go skydiving?"
Person #1: "Hell no! Jumping out of an airplane is stupid and dangerous."
Person #2: "Hell yeah! It must be an amazing experience!"
- **For real / I'll say! / Seriously.** = I definitely agree with your statement; your statement is totally true.
"We are getting so much snow this winter, it's insane!"
"Seriously! My kids' school has been cancelled at least ten times."
- **Word / True dat** = I agree / That's true (hip-hop slang)
- **Yeah right.** = A sarcastic expression meaning "I don't believe you."
"I cooked this entire meal myself."
"Yeah, right! You barely know how to fry an egg."
"Haha, you know me too well. Yeah, it's from a restaurant."
- **Attaboy! / Attagirl!** = Good job! (Short form of "That's the boy/girl!")
Situation: Your best friend is trying to lose weight, and she tells you she went to the gym every day this week. You can say "Attagirl!" to approve of her action and encourage her.

- **Be my guest.** = Go ahead, you have permission
"Hey, can I use your phone for a quick call? My cell phone battery is dead."
*"Sure, **be my guest.**"*

Slang Words for Time/Quantity

If someone is **dilly-dallying**, it means they are being slow and wasting time (especially someone who is taking a long time to make a decision). A person who moves, works, or acts slowly in general can also be called a **slowpoke**.

- "Come on kids, stop **dilly-dallying** – we have to leave for school!"
- "I didn't post pictures from our vacation until six weeks after we'd gotten back – I know, I'm a **slowpoke**!"

When something happens exactly, precisely at the right time, it happens **on the dot**. And when something gets done very fast, it happens **in a jiffy/snap**. If you need something **pronto**, it means you need it as soon as possible.

- "The performance started at 9:00 **on the dot**."
- "My best friend's so funny. Whenever I'm upset, she can cheer me up **in a snap**."
- "I'm so stressed out. I need a vacation **pronto**!"

Alternative words for "lots" include **heaps, loads, piles, oodles**, and **tons**; and a small amount of something can be described as **a tad, a lick**, or **a smidgen**. The words **chock-full** and **jam-packed** mean something is totally full of something else.

- "There are **loads** of great educational videos on YouTube, but there are **tons** of stupid and pointless videos as well."
- "Put just **a smidgen** of mayonnaise on my sandwich – not too much."
- "He's been studying for years, but he still can't speak a **lick** of English."
("a lick of" is usually used in the negative like this. "It doesn't make a lick of sense," "he didn't do a lick of work," etc.)
- "This book is worth reading; it's **chock-full** of interesting tips and insights."
- "We had an exciting, **jam-packed** weekend." (=full of activities)

Exaggerated ways to say "a very large number" include **zillion, bazillion**, and **gazillion** – these are not real numbers; they are just a play on the words "million, billion, trillion, etc."

- “Boots like those used to be considered ugly, but now they’re in style and **zillions** of people are wearing them.”
- “There were **a gazillion** people at the beach; we could barely find a place to sit.”

For an unspecified quantity that is large, but not as large as a zillion, we can use the word **umpteen**. This is often used in the expression **umpteenth time**:

- “My dad is totally clueless when it comes to computers. He just asked me how to delete a file for the **umpteenth time**.” (=he has asked me many, many times)

A slang word for “big” is **ginormous** (gigantic + enormous), or you can describe it as a **monster**. If something is the **mother of all** [things], it is one of the biggest.

- “They’re really rich; they live in a **ginormous** mansion on the beach with something like 50 rooms.”
- “A **monster** hurricane is about to hit the east coast; lots of towns are being evacuated.”
- “In my opinion, laziness is the **mother of all** bad habits.”

Something that is small can be described as **pint-sized** (often used to talk about children or people of small stature), **itty-bitty/itsy-bitsy**, or **teeny/teensy/teeny-tiny/teensy-weensy**.

- “Scientists have created a **pint-sized** robot that can clean your house for you.”
- “This gold necklace is decorated with **itty-bitty** diamonds in the design.”
- “I was just a **teensy** bit jealous when my sister won a free trip to Europe in a radio show contest.”

Finally, there are a number of slang words for “zero”: **zilch, nil, zip, squat / diddly-squat, jack** (usually in the expression “doesn’t/don’t know jack”)

- “The number of interesting things to do in this town is practically **zilch**.”
- “They’re not gonna win. The score is 3-**nil** (3 to 0) and there are only 15 minutes left in the game.”
- “You don’t know **jack** about the situation, so your opinion about it means **diddly-squat**.”

Slang Words for Movement & Places

A **high-five** is when you slap another person's open hand; it's used for congratulations. People often say "**Gimme five!**" when they want you to do this.

If you're taking a **road trip**, it means you're taking a long trip by car. You'll need make regular **pit stops** – pauses in the trip to go to the bathroom or get food/drinks. If your car is a **clunker**, it means it's an old car that's not in the best conditions.

- "During summer vacation, we took a **road trip** down the coast of California."
- "Guys, I'm thirsty. Let's make a **pit stop** soon."
- "I love my old car, but its maintenance costs a fortune – I think it's time to get rid of this **clunker** and buy a new car."

Remember to drive safely – don't **tailgate** (follow too closely behind the car in front of you). Another unsafe maneuver is to **pop a wheelie** – when someone riding a bicycle or motorcycle lifts the front wheel off the ground while in movement.

- "The guy behind us is **tailgating** us – better change lanes and just let him pass."
- "Bobby broke his collarbone when he fell off his motorcycle while trying to **pop a wheelie**."

One thing many pedestrians do in cities is **jaywalking** – crossing a street illegally (for example, when the light is green, or in the middle of the road and not at the correct place).

- "The police officer reprimanded us for **jaywalking**."

To **haul ass** is a slang word for to move very fast – this can be running or driving.

- "We only have 10 minutes to catch our connecting flight, so we're gonna have to **haul ass** in the airport."

Informal words for "leave" include **split** and **jet** – so you can say "**Let's split**" to mean "Let's leave" or "**I'm gonna jet**" for "I'm going to leave now." If you abandon your friend(s) without telling them, you have **ditched** them. "Ditch" can mean to abandon people or to get rid of / throw away an object:

- "I can't believe you **ditched** me at the party and left me all alone with nobody to talk to!"

- “I finally **ditched** my old college textbooks – not sure why I was keeping them; I hadn’t opened them in the past 20 years.”

Inside a city, the word **hood** is short for neighborhood (often a low-income neighborhood). There is also the word **turf**, which means territory under someone’s influence – such as the land under the control of a particular gang, but it can mean any area under the authority/influence of a person/group.

- “Everyone in the **hood** knows Johnny, he owns the most popular bar in the area.”
- “The baseball team isn’t doing so well – they’ve lost their last five games, even though they were playing on their home **turf**.”

The **burbs** are the suburbs – the often upper-middle-class areas outside major cities in the U.S. More remote rural areas can be called **the boonies, the boondocks, or the sticks**. These all have a rather negative connotation, as places that are isolated, boring, and underdeveloped.

- “When my parents retired, they left the city and moved to a nice house in the **burbs**.”
- “My uncle lives way out in the **boonies** – you can’t even get cell phone reception at his place.”

The expression **“smack dab in the middle”** means that something is located exactly in the middle of a particular area or time span. And if a place is in **“the middle of nowhere,”** it is *extremely* isolated.

- “There’s a crazy guy sitting **smack dab in the middle** of the highway! He’d better get out of there before he gets hurt.”
- “The center for the meditation retreat is **in the middle of nowhere** – the nearest town is 30 miles away.”

Someone’s **pad, crib** or **digs** is their home or place of residence. If you stay over at someone’s home for free, you **crash** with the person.

- “She’s got a **pad** on the upper west side of the city.”
- “I saw photos of your new apartment online. Nice **digs**!”
- “I’ll be in town for a couple of days next week – could I **crash** with you?”

One slang word for the bathroom or toilet is the **john** or the **crapper** (referring to the fact that you can “take a crap” – defecate – there). “Crapper” is often used in the

expression “in the crapper” (in terrible condition) or “going down the crapper” (becoming worse, becoming terrible).

- “After drinking all that beer, I woke up to use the **john** five times during the night.”
- “The team’s record **went down the crapper** after their star player got injured.”

When there’s a house/apartment in horrible, dirty, broken conditions, you can say “This place is a **dump**.” Another way to describe a terrible area to live/work is a **shithole**, and the worst and ugliest part of a particular area (often an urban area) can be called the **armpit**.

- “Everything’s covered in trash, the plumbing doesn’t work, and there are rats running all over the kitchen. What a **dump**!”
- “Yeah, the house is cheap, but it’s also a **shithole**. You’ll have to spend a fortune on fixing it up.”
- “This area is the **armpit** of the city, with a high crime rate and lots of pollution.”

Finally, there are a number of slang words for prison or jail, including **the slammer**, **the clink**, and **the can**. Before going to prison, the police take a **mug shot** (official photo before entering prison) of the criminal.

- “He spent five years in the **slammer** after assaulting his girlfriend.”

Slang for Problems & Mistakes

A few informal nouns for a mistake are a **blooper**, **boo-boo**, and **blunder**. We also have **hiccup**, which means a minor problem/mistake that was corrected and didn’t affect the final result/outcome.

- “The soccer team’s defensive **blunder** resulted in their opponents scoring the winning goal.”
- “Aside from a few **hiccups** in communication among the team members, the whole event went off without a hitch.” (*without a hitch = perfectly*)

For the act of making mistakes, we have phrasal verbs like **slip up**, **screw up**, **foul up**, and **fuck up**, and funny-sounding verbs like **flub** and **bungle**.

- “My girlfriend got so mad when I **slipped up** and called her by my ex’s name!”
- “He has low self-confidence because he feels like he’s always **screwing up**.”
- “I totally **flubbed** my introduction to the presentation – I said everything in the wrong order.”

When something fails, we can say it was **a flop** or **a dud**, or say that it **bombed** or it **tanked**. These expressions are usually used for sudden, obvious failures. When something progressively gets worse over time, it is **going down the drain/tubes** or **going to the dogs/going to pot**.

- “We tried to start a club, but it was **a flop**. We were hoping for at least fifteen people, but only two signed up.”
- “A lot of people lost their jobs when the economy **tanked**.”
- “Some of my friends say this country is **going to the dogs**, but I disagree – I think things are slowly but surely getting better.”

You might make a **last-ditch effort** (a desperate, final effort) to fix the problem; your last option is called the **last resort**. But if it doesn’t work, then you’re really **in a jam** (in a difficult situation).

- “After spilling coffee all over my computer, I made a **last-ditch effort** to recover the data: I took it to a repair shop to see if they could at least salvage the hard drive.”
- “That medication has a bunch of serious side effects; doctors only prescribe it as a **last resort**.”
- “I know I can always count on my brother’s help whenever I’m **in a jam**.”

You’ll have to tell your supervisors... trying to cover up the mistake is a **sure-fire** (definite) way to have bigger problems later on. If your boss finds out, you’ll be **busted** (caught doing/having done something wrong, and consequently in trouble).

- “Getting more sleep is a **sure-fire** way to increase your energy and productivity during the day.”
- “At the airport, I saw a guy get **busted** trying to enter the country with a fake passport.”

Hopefully when you tell your supervisors about the mistake, they will **let it slide** (not punish you for your mistake). However, if they think you **can’t hack it** (can’t handle the responsibility effectively) or if your work is **not up to par / not up to snuff** (does not meet the minimum standards), then you might lose your job!

- “You’re half an hour late. I’ll **let it slide** this time, but don’t make a habit of it.”
- “Sarah worked as a journalist for a month, but she **couldn’t hack it** – she wasn’t able to finish her stories on time for the strict deadlines.”
- “The service at that restaurant is just **not up to par**. I won’t be eating there again.”

Let’s talk about success. If something **works like magic / works like a charm**, it works perfectly and effectively.

- “This new detergent **works like magic** for getting stains out of white clothing.”

When you have a lot of successes in a row, or a lot of positive momentum in your action, you are **on a roll**.

- “I’ve gotten the highest grade in the class on the past three tests. I’m really on a roll this semester!”

If you’re on a roll, just keep up the good work and **you’ve got it made** (success for you is certain).

- “If you study an area like computer science, where there’s always a huge number of high-paying jobs, **you’ve got it made**.”

Slang Words for Situations & Actions

Slang words for parties include a **bash**, a **shindig**, and a **get-together** – these refer to more informal parties (not formal events or official celebrations).

- “We’re all going to Jenna’s 30th birthday **bash** this weekend!”
- “Every month or so my circle of friends has a little **get-together** at someone’s house.”

If a party is **dead**, it means it is not very exciting. But if it was **chill**, it means it was relaxed. **Chill** can also be used as a verb, meaning to spend time in a relaxed way (the same as **hang out**).

- “This club is totally **dead**, there’s practically no one dancing. Let’s get outta here.”

- “It was rainy so I spent the day **chillin’** with my brother and watching some of our favorite comedies.”

If a place or situation has **good vibes** or **bad vibes**, it means it has a good/bad energy ("Vibes" is short for "vibrations"). It can also be used in the singular. A vibe is like a feeling or impression that you get, even if you can't clearly identify the reason.

- “I believe if you give out **good vibes** to everybody around you, good things will happen to you.”
- “I just don't trust him. I'm not sure why, exactly, I just get some **bad vibes** from the way he acts.”

Slang words for something that is easy include **a breeze, a cinch, a snap**, or **a cakewalk**. On the other hand, if something is difficult, you can say it's **a tall order** (often a request that is difficult to fulfill), **a bitch**, **no picnic** (not an easy/pleasant experience) or use the expression, “You have your work cut out for you” (meaning you need to do difficult tasks).

- “Installing an app on your cell phone is **a breeze** – just push this button and the process happens automatically.”
- “Compared to my military training, that exercise class was **a cakewalk**.”
- “The last question on the physics exam was **a bitch** – it took me four solid pages of calculations to solve it!”
- “Having three kids under the age of five is **no picnic**. I feel like I can't get a moment of rest.”

When you know that something is certain to be achieved, you can say it is **in the bag** or that it **should be a slam dunk**. If a candidate or competitor is certain to get a job or a position, he/she is a **shoo-in**.

- “Although they didn't directly offer me the job, we agreed on a salary and they asked what day I could start – so I'm pretty sure it's **in the bag**.”
(= I'll definitely get the job)
- “Helen is a very popular leader who has done a lot to help the community – she'll be **a shoo-in** for re-election as the city mayor.”

If something is unsure, it is **dicey, iffy, a toss-up**, or **up in the air**. Something that is unlikely to happen is a **long shot**, and if you think there's almost no chance of something happening, you could say **"Fat chance"** (sarcastic) or that something has **no chance in hell** (or **doesn't have a snowball's chance in hell**).

- “The economic recovery is still **dicey**. It’s been growing, but the experts say we could still have another big crash.”
- “I’m not sure which pair of jeans to buy – it’s a **toss-up** between this dark blue pair and that light blue one.”
(we often use “toss-up” for an undecided choice between two items)
- “Our Christmas plans are still **up in the air** – we might travel, or we might stay home. It depends on which days I can get off from work.”
(“up in the air” is often used when your future plans are uncertain)
- “The Red Sox will win the world championship? **Fat chance!** They’re the worst team in the league right now.”
- “There’s **no chance in hell** I’ll trust her after the way she betrayed me!”

When a situation is uncertain, sometimes you need to make a guess. If your guess is **bang on** or **spot on**, it means it was accurate. Another way to say that someone made a perfectly true or accurate statement is to say they **nailed it**. But if the prediction or idea was **off-base** or **missed the mark**, it was inaccurate.

- “Your prediction about the movie was **spot on** – it was nowhere near as good as the book, just like you imagined.”
- “Kathryn **nailed it** when she said that outdated technology is holding us back. We could produce 80% more products if we had better equipment.”
- “Your sales estimates were way **off-base**. We sold 35% less merchandise than you predicted.”
- “It was an interesting book, but I thought a few of the ideas **missed the mark** – they just didn’t match up with reality.”

When someone is complaining about something, you can say **“tough shit”** if you are unsympathetic – meaning it’s a hard situation, but they need to accept it and stop complaining. Other ways to tell someone to endure difficulty without complaining include:

- **get over it**
*“Laura’s been crying over her ex-boyfriend for the past four months. **Get over it** already!”*
- **suck it up**
*“Nobody likes doing the hard work, but sometimes you just need to **suck it up** and do your best, even if you don’t get everything perfectly right.”*

- **man up** / **grow a pair** (used only to men)
*"What do you mean you're scared to ask Lisa out? Come on, dude, **grow a pair** and go invite her to lunch – what's the worst that could happen?"*

An informal way to say someone has an advantage is to say they have a **leg up**, or if someone does an action earlier than you, that person **beat you to the punch**.

- "Investing in your education will give you a **leg up** when it comes to getting the best jobs."
- "My girlfriend and I were both unhappy in the relationship and I was going to break up with her, but she **beat me to the punch** and dumped me first."

There are several informal ways to describe disadvantageous situations:

- If someone **has you by the short hairs** or **has you over a barrel**, it means they have complete power/control of the situation; you do not have many choices or options.
*"The price of supplies has gone up, and there's nothing we can do about it – our supplier **has us over a barrel**; they're the only ones who manufacture the product we need."*
- If you **get the shaft (or get shafted)**, **get a raw deal**, or **get the short end of the stick**, it means you get the worst part or are treated unfairly.
*"Whoever says racism no longer exists in this country is delusional. People of color always **get the shaft** – especially when it comes to justice."
*"The organization wants YOU to pay in order to do volunteer work for them? I don't know, that sounds like **a raw deal** to me."**
- If someone **screws you over**, they manipulate the situation to take advantage of you.
*"I don't give second chances to people who **screw me over**. Once the trust is gone, it's gone forever."*

Sometimes there's a new product, movie, topic, etc. about which there's a lot of **hype** (excessive publicity and media/public attention). If everybody's talking about it, you could also say there is a lot of **buzz** (excited interest/attention). The difference is that "hype" implies it is too much, more than the topic deserves. Another way to say people get very excited/interested/crazy about something is to say they **go gaga** over it.

- "The critics are all raving about the movie, but my friends and I didn't think it was that great. Don't believe the **hype**."

- “There’s been a lot of **buzz** over Google’s newest invention – a pair of glasses that lets you access the internet right in front of your eyes. Everyone’s talking about how this could revolutionize daily life.”
- “Fans are **going gaga** over the band’s latest album, which is said to be its best work ever.”

To describe a situation in which there are lots of people or almost everybody, you can use the expressions **everybody and his uncle/brother**:

- “It seemed like **everybody and his brother** was at the supermarket today; I was waiting in line for 40 minutes!”

A similar expression for lots of objects, almost everything, is **everything but the kitchen sink**:

- “Whenever we go on a trip, my wife packs **everything but the kitchen sink** and we end up with three enormous suitcases.”

When you need to do something difficult without the necessary experience or ability, you are **flying by the seat of your pants**. A similar expression is **on the fly** - when you need to improvise and create something in that moment. Don't get “on the fly” confused with **on the sly**, which means secretly and/or deceptively.

- “We were really **flying by the seat of our pants** on that project – none of the team members had any experience in the area, so we just had to do our best and hope it would work!”
- “The main speaker canceled at the last minute, so I had to give a presentation on the topic **on the fly**.”
- “I made my roommate help pay for groceries when I discovered he had been eating my food **on the sly**.”

When something is especially intense, it can be described as **hardcore**; and something that is extremely amusing or absurd can be described as **priceless**.

- “He’s doing a **hardcore** English course – classes from 9-noon and 1-4 every single day.”
- “Her reaction when she saw the fake spider I put on her pillow was **priceless**! She screamed and practically fell out of bed.”

When something can be taken or won by anyone, it is **up for grabs**. But if there is a small selection of things/options, these are called **slim pickings**.

- “I have three extra tickets to the baseball game that are **up for grabs** – anyone want ‘em?”
- “I joined a couple of online dating sites but felt like there were **slim pickings** – a lot of guys’ profiles, but few who would really be compatible with me.”

To call **“dibs”** on something means to claim it as yours, and to **bag, snag,** or **score** something means to get/obtain it.

- “I call **dibs** on the last piece of leftover pizza. Don’t even think about eating it!”
- “There’s a great end-of-season sale at H&M, I **snagged** some really nice shoes for 30% off.”
- “I won a contest and **scored** a free iPad!”

To **put the kibosh on** something is to stop an activity or prevent it from happening:

- “The rain **put the kibosh on** our plans to go camping.”

To **get on someone’s case** means to persistently remind a person to do something (in an annoying way). You can also say **“Get off my case!”** to tell the other person to STOP doing this.

- “I know I need to start a diet and lose a couple pounds, but my mom’s always **getting on my case** about it. I don’t need to be reminded!”

A **switcheroo** is an unexpected change or reversal. It’s often used with the verb “pull”:

- “The president pulled a **switcheroo** – last year he supported laws for protecting the environment, and this year he’s saying such laws hinder growth and development.”

Positive Slang Words

Slang ways to describe something good or great include:

- **sweet/cool/phat/fresh/fly/killer/wicked/dope/rad**

(These are all adjectives)

*“I just discovered a **sweet** website where you can listen to music for free.”*

*"Whoa, your new surfboard is **wicked!**"*

*"He's got a **killer** sound system in his car."*

- **slick, snazzy** = stylish, attractive

*"Hey, that's a **snazzy** leather jacket. Where did you get it?"*

- **It rocks. / It rules. / It's the bomb.** = It's really great

*"That TV show **rocks!** Every episode is amazing."*

- **I really dig it.** = I really like it

*"**I really dig** philosophy. I love thinking about the deep questions in life."*

A slang expression for a situation that is completely good in all aspects is to say **everything is hunky-dory.**

- "There were a few conflicts in the early days of our club, but we worked them out and now **everything is hunky-dory.**"

When you want to give praise, thanks, or credit to someone, you give them **kudos** or **props**. Another slang word for a public expression of gratitude or recognition is a **shout-out**.

- "I want to give **props** to the technical team, who helped tonight's show run smoothly."
- "**Kudos** to my brother, who just got his article published in the country's top magazine."
- "I'd like to give a **shout-out** to my best friend – without her support, I never would have had the persistence to keep going and to win this award today."

The word **badass** means someone or something that is *extremely* cool, perhaps in an "edgy" or "dangerous"-looking way. The word **kickass** can also be used for something great, but it's only for objects, not people.

- "My first boyfriend looked like a **badass**, with his motorcycle and lots of tattoos, but he was really a very sweet guy."
- "I just bought a **kickass** new video camera – it's one of the most advanced cameras available today."

If you do something good that earns you favor with someone else, you have earned **"brownie points"** – that's an imaginary form of social currency.

- "Any man who opens the door for a lady automatically gets **brownie points** in my mind!"

Negative Slang Words

Ways to describe something bad include:

- **crummy** (= poor quality)
*"This **crummy** flashlight just broke – oh well, at least I only paid a dollar for it."*
- **Crappy / shitty / piss-poor** (= very poor quality)
*"He did such a **shitty** job on that report that I had to rewrite it from scratch."
(from scratch = from the beginning)*
- **lame** (= disappointing & pathetic)
*"The workshop about increasing your self-confidence was **lame**. The speaker didn't teach anything new, he just talked about himself the whole time!"*
- **It sucks/blows/stinks** (= the situation is terrible, unfortunate)
*"You have to work all weekend and you don't get paid any extra? Wow, that **sucks**."*
- **cheesy, corny** (= rather stupid, silly)
*"The movie was all about a love story, but I thought it was kinda **cheesy** and predictable."*
- **a bummer** (= it's a shame, it's a little bit sad)
*"The ski trip was canceled because not enough people were interested in going. What a **bummer**."*
- **a drag** (= it's boring/difficult)
*"Working as a cashier is such a **drag**! There's no variety in the work and I have to deal with impatient customers all day."*
- **bogus** (= it's fake, not true/real/genuine)
*"I got a **bogus** email claiming to be from my bank, but really it was a scam or a virus."*
- **That's wack. / What a joke.** (= that's absurd, stupid, unfair)
*"How is it possible that someone can be sentenced to ten years in prison for drugs, but politicians who steal millions of dollars get off the hook? **That's wack**." (get off the hook = avoid a punishment)*

When two or three events have a major negative impact, this is a **double whammy** or **triple whammy**:

- “First I got pneumonia, and when I recovered I developed a serious infection. It was a **double whammy** that made me miss an entire semester of school.”

If something gets a **bad rap/bad rep**, it means it gets a bad reputation (sometimes deserving it, but sometimes not). If someone is **getting/taking a lot of flak**, it means they are receiving a lot of criticism (often more than the situation deserves).

- “That country gets a **bad rap** because of terrorism, but most parts of it are actually quite safe.”
- “The actress **got a lot of flak** when she appeared in public without makeup; journalists commented that she was ‘not taking care of herself.’”

When a machine is not functioning, you can say it’s **busted** or **on the fritz**. If something electronic is not working (usually temporarily), it is **dead**, but if a part is COMPLETELY broken and cannot be repaired, it is **shot**.

- “The water heater is **busted**, so we’re taking cold showers.”
- “My laptop is **dead** – I need to plug it in to recharge the battery.”
- “The mechanic said that my car’s engine is **shot**, and that replacing it will cost at least a thousand bucks.”

Let’s say you bring your broken refrigerator to the repair shop, and they fix part of it, but they don’t fix it completely. You can complain to your friend, “It was a **half-assed** repair; I had to bring it back in!” **Half-assed** means something was not done completely or properly.

We have a lot of informal words for being dirty. Another word for “dirt” is **crud**, and something can be **scuzzy** (dirty/disgusting) or **grungy** (dirty/run down). When a room or space is very dirty, it can be described as a **pigpen** or **pigsty** – a place where pigs live.

- “When I cleaned the kitchen, it took me an hour to remove all the **crud** from the back of the cabinets.”
- “You should wear a **grungy** old T-shirt when you paint the house, so that it doesn’t matter if it gets dirty.”
- “His car is a total **pigsty**! There are fast food wrappers all over the floor and it looks like he hasn’t cleaned it in months.”

As you learned in a previous section, someone who is dirty and doesn’t take care of themselves or their living space is a **slob**. On the other hand, someone who is extremely and sometimes excessively neat is a **neatnik** or **clean freak**.

- “My best friend is a **clean freak**. Her house is always completely spotless.”

Finally, there are many variations for saying you don't care at all (in a rude way): **"I don't give a... damn / shit / fuck / rat's ass."**

- “People criticized me when I chose to quit my job and stay home with my kids, but **I don't give a shit** what they think. It's my life and it's none of their business!”

Shortened Words & Abbreviations

- **ad** = advertisement
*“Have you seen the new McDonald's **ad**? It's pretty funny.”*
- **ain't** = isn't, am not, aren't
*“He wants to borrow my car? No way. That **ain't** gonna happen.”*
(this is very non-standard English; it is considered incorrect)
- **ammo** = ammunition – both literal ammunition for weapons and “ammunition” to be used in an argument
*“The police intercepted a truck trying to smuggle tons of weapons and **ammo** into the country.”*
- **app** = application (as on a smart phone)
*“I have an **app** on my phone that teaches me a new English phrase every day.”*
- **a beaut** = a beauty
*“My brother and I both love classic cars. He has a 1960 Cadillac, and it's a **beaut**.”*
- **carbs** = carbohydrates
*“I'm going to try a low-**carb** diet – no more pizza or breakfast cereal for me.”*
- **cig** = cigarette (and **light** = lighter or match)
*“I could really use a **cig** right now.”*

*"Hey, have you got a **light**?"*

- **comfy** = comfortable
*"These pants are really **comfy** – they're perfect for yoga or dance."*
- **cred (or street cred)** = credibility, acceptability, popularity, especially among young people in urban areas
*"Sometimes rich teens like to dress like gangsters – but they have no **street cred** whatsoever."*
- **demo** = demonstration
*"Let me give you a **demo** of how the software works."*
- **doc** = doctor
*"The **doc** said that avoiding spicy foods would help with my digestive problems."*
- **fab** = fabulous
*"Wow, you look **fab** in that dress! It's a great style for you."*
- **info** = information
*"I'm interested in the class, but I need more **info** before I sign up."*
- **intel** = intelligence (military information gathered from observation)
*"The government's **intel** has identified several possible threats."*
- **intro** = introduction
*"The first module of the program is just an **intro** to the course."*
- **lab** = laboratory
*"My husband's a biologist, so he works in a **lab**, not an office."*
- **legit** = legitimate
*"The story seems incredible, but I've checked all the facts and it's totally **legit**."*

- **limo** = limousine
*"The celebrities arrived at the banquet in **limos**."*
- **mag** = magazine
*"I like to read the fashion **mags** while waiting in line at the supermarket."*
- **meds** = medications
*"He's taking strong **meds** to help control his depression."*
- **OD** = overdose
(often of drugs, but is casually used for over-indulging in other things)
*"She was taken to the hospital after **ODing** on heroin."*
- **OJ** = orange juice
*"Do you want milk or **OJ** with your breakfast?"*
- **perp** = perpetrator, the person who committed a crime (police slang)
*"The witnesses gave a detailed description of both **perps**."*
- **preemie** = baby that was born prematurely, early (hospital slang)
*"Many **preemies** need machines to help them breathe until their lungs fully develop."*
- **pre-nup** = pre-nuptial agreement: a contract signed by a man and woman before marriage, defining how their money and possessions will be divided if they separate in the future
*"Couples that don't sign a **pre-nup** sometimes have ugly legal battles if they end up divorcing."*
- **prep** = preparation, prepare
*"The singer is backstage, **prepping** for her performance in a few minutes."*
- **pro** = professional, or someone who is very good at an activity
*"Are you sure she's never taken a dance class? Because she dances like a **pro**!"*

- **prof** = professor (college professor)
*"One of my English **profs** was the person who inspired me to become a writer."*
- **promo** = promotion, promotional
*"I booked the flight for half-price during a holiday **promo**."*
- **Q and A** = questions and answers
*"At the end of my presentation, I'll leave a little time for **Q and A**."*
- **ref** = referee, the official who makes decisions in a sports game
*"The **ref** made a bad call – he awarded the point, but the ball was clearly out of bounds."*
- **regs** = regulations
*"The company had to pay a fine for violating a number of safety **regs**."*
- **rehab** = rehabilitation, often for drug and alcohol addictions
*"That celebrity has some serious problems – she's just gone to **rehab** for the third time in a year."*
- **rep** = representative
*"The sales **rep** explained the difference between the various types of the product."*
- **sax** = saxophone
*"I've played the **sax** since I was a kid."*
- **stats** = statistics
*"According to **stats** from this past year, there are now more women in college than men."*
- **sub** = substitute or submarine
*"All the kids misbehave when there's a **sub** in the classroom."
"The navy sent a **sub** to attack the enemy battleship."*

- **tech** = technology
*"That country is investing heavily in clean energy **tech**."*
- **teen** = teenager
*"We have two **teen** girls, so our family's phone bill is through the roof!"
(through the roof = extremely high)*
- **tux** = tuxedo
*"He rented a **tux** for the wedding."*
- **undies** = underwear
*"Pull your pants up – your **undies** are showing."*
- **uni** = university
*"Alan was the first in his family to graduate from **uni**."*
- **vet** = veterinarian
*"My daughter Gisele loves animals; she wants to be a **vet** when she grows up."*
- **vocab** = vocabulary
*"Watching documentaries has helped me learn a lot of new **vocab**."*

Text Message Abbreviations

(No audio because these are not spoken!)

When chatting online or exchanging text messages, English speakers often use abbreviations for certain words and phrases. Remember, these should **ONLY** be used in very informal chats and messages, and not for e-mails to teachers or colleagues... and *never* in formal writing!

It's common to type the number **2** to substitute the word or syllable "to" (2nite = tonight) and the number **4** to substitute the word or syllable "for" (B4N = bye for now). Here are some other common abbreviations:

- **BRB** = be right back
(when you will step away from your computer/phone for a moment)

- **BTW** = by the way
(used to add a new fact, which may be unrelated to the topic)
- **CYA** = see ya
(used to say goodbye, or “see you later”)
- **FML** = fuck my life
(when something bad happens to you, or you are in a bad situation)
- **FTW** = for the win
(means something is the best, or accomplished something amazing)
- **FWIW** = for what it’s worth
(used to add a comment that may not be the final/complete truth, but could be helpful)
- **GR8** = great
- **GTG** = gotta go
- **HMU** = hit me up
(this means “contact me”)
- **IDK / IDC** = I don’t know / I don’t care
- **ILY** = I love you
- **IRL** = in real life (also RL for “real life”)
- **IMO / IMHO** = in my opinion / in my humble opinion
- **JK** = just kidding
- **kk** = OK
- **LMAO / ROTFLMAO**
= laughing my ass off / rolling on the floor laughing my ass off
- **LOL** = laughing out loud
- **meh** = a mediocre feeling; you don’t have strong feelings about something
- **NP** = no problem
- **NM / NVM** = never mind
- **OIC** = oh, I see
- **OMG** = oh my god
- **OTOH** = on the other hand
(used to present a contrasting point)
- **PLS/PLZ** = please
- **POV** = point of view
- **sup** = what’s up?
(used as a greeting, or to find out what the other person is doing)

- **TBH** = to be honest
(to introduce a comment that may be negative, but is your honest opinion)
- **THX / TX / THKS / TY** = thanks, thank you
- **TMI** = too much information
(in reaction to someone sharing too much personal or intimate information)
- **TTYL** = talk to you later
- **W/E** = whatever
- **WTF** = what the fuck?
(used when angry or shocked about something)
- **XOXO** = hugs and kisses
- **YMMV** = your mileage may vary
(used when making a suggestion about something that worked for you, but may or may not work for other people)
- **YW** = you're welcome

You've finished the Slang & Informal English E-Book!

I hope you enjoyed it 😊

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accelerate your English learning:**

